



Price pressures

India must find sources of sustainable energy to curb inflation

The new series of the Consumer Price Index (CPI), the second data release of which was issued on Thursday, does not yet have enough historical data for robust comparisons, but does include enough information to provide clues about the future. Retail inflation in India quickened to a 10-month high of 3.2% in February 2026, largely driven by food inflation and precious metal prices. This rise is something that the government should take note of early, avoiding any complacency that might have crept in due to the low inflation levels of the last year or so. Food has a lower weight in the new series as compared to the old one, but is nevertheless a major driver of inflation with a 36.75% weight in the overall CPI. Inflation in food and beverages rose to 3.35% in February from 2.1% in the previous month, driven by quickening price levels in the meat, oils, and fruits and nuts categories. Notably, inflation in tomato prices stood at more than 45%. Thankfully, this was accompanied by a contraction in prices of the two other staples – onions and potatoes – by 28% and 18%, respectively. A large part of the low inflation last year was due to a statistical base effect that is now gone. Looking ahead, there are various factors that could result in rapidly rising food inflation. The first is that climate scientists are predicting the return of the El Niño effect in the middle of the monsoon this year. A weak monsoon will naturally raise food prices. The second impact will depend on how long the conflict in West Asia continues. Sustained natural gas supply constraints will hurt fertilizer production, affecting food output and, eventually, prices.

The other factor that has driven inflation up, and which will likely remain a major driver in the near future, is the price of gold and silver. Gold jewellery saw inflation rise to 48.2% in February from an already-blistering 46.8% in January. Inflation in silver jewellery stood at more than 160% in both January and February. With global uncertainty and anxiety skyrocketing, the demand for safe-haven precious metals is not going to let up any time soon. Rising oil prices and LPG and LNG shortages are already raising input prices for industry, which will eventually be passed on to consumers. The Reserve Bank of India's Monetary Policy Committee has a tough job in its next meeting in April. Inflation is being driven by supply constraints, so trying to reduce demand by raising interest rates will not only have a minimal impact on inflation but could also further hurt growth when fuel constraints are already impacting it. The onus lies with the government and its efforts to expedite alternative sources of fuel.

Duty of care

The state must not evade responsibility when it pushes for vaccination

The Supreme Court of India's directive in *Rachana Gangu* to the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare to design a no-fault compensation scheme for serious adverse events following immunisation (AEFI) arising from India's COVID-19 vaccination campaign marks a shift from a fault-based liability system to a no-fault one in state-run public health programmes. The case arose from writ petitions filed in various courts by families claiming that their relatives had died or suffered serious injury after receiving COVID-19 vaccines. *Rachana Gangu* was over the deaths, in 2021, of two women aged 18 and 20, allegedly from vaccine-induced immune thrombotic thrombocytopenia (VITT), a rare complication of the Covishield vaccine. Affected families contended that India had no dedicated mechanism to compensate those harmed in a state-run programme. For several years, the government resisted establishing a compensation policy because it held that vaccination was voluntary, serious AEFI rates were extremely low, and aggrieved citizens could sue vaccine manufacturers in civil court – a position the Court has since rejected as being impractical for ordinary individuals. The new ruling also builds on *Jacob Puliyel* (2022), in which the Court rejected challenges to emergency vaccine approvals but emphasised the need to make AEFI data publicly available.

In 2024, a few years after scientists had established the same concern in medical literature, AstraZeneca acknowledged in a U.K. court document that Covishield could, in rare instances, cause VITT. Since most Indians were vaccinated with Covishield, the admission further undermined the government's position that links between the vaccine and certain deaths were unproven or coincidental. Despite operating one of the world's largest immunisation efforts, India has historically lacked a dedicated national vaccine injury compensation programme. Many countries, including the U.S. and the U.K., have such vaccine injury compensation programmes where claimants need not prove negligence, but only a plausible link to vaccination. Even the global COVAX facility established a no-fault mechanism for 92 low- and middle-income countries. During the pandemic, the government had reported over 1,100 deaths following vaccination across 219 crore doses administered. The Court ruled that for a welfare state, these represent individual human lives and that the absence of a formal policy left affected families in a legal vacuum. It has also been clear that its directive is not based on adjudicating whether the vaccines caused specific injuries or deaths nor does it replace all fault-based liabilities in public health. However, it sets an important precedent for future vaccination drives, including the new one for HPV, affirming the state's duty of care when endorsing medical interventions for the public good.

Once upon a late-20th-century lecture circuit, the phrase “Washington Consensus” (WC) did the work of a talisman: 10 tidy policy prescriptions that promised macro stability, market-led growth, and a path out of crisis for beleaguered states. John Williamson, who coined the term in 1989, formulated its 10 commandments: fiscal discipline; reordering public spending toward pro-growth priorities; tax reform to broaden the tax base and lower rates; liberalisation of interest rates; competitive exchange rates; trade liberalisation through lowering tariffs; liberalisation of inward foreign direct investment; privatisation of state-owned enterprises; deregulation to remove barriers to entry and competition; and securing property rights. These were presented as near-universal remedies, administered by institutions in the West that watched the global macro-economy like physicians with a single, favoured prescription, summed up in the words liberalise, privatise, and deregulate. Three decades on, the prescription seems obsolete, overtaken by the onrush of global events.

Its shaping, its legacy

The Washington Consensus was never merely technocratic; it carried a political history. Adopted in moments of crisis, its reforms arrived bound up with conditionality, bargaining power, and a belief that markets, once set free, would generate growth that trickled down. The core tenets of the “consensus” emerged from the ideological crucible of Reaganomics and Thatcherite structural adjustment programmes. These principles – fiscal austerity, deregulation, privatisation, and trade liberalisation – were adopted with little critical scrutiny by the Bretton Woods Institutions (the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund, or BWIs) and their regional counterparts such as the Asian Development Bank during the mid to late 1980s. Their embrace was largely a response to the debt crises and macroeconomic instability that afflicted many developing countries at the time.

Yet, the consequences of this orthodoxy were far-reaching and, in many cases, deeply destabilising. The Asian financial crisis, which erupted in Bangkok in 1997, and the global financial meltdown of 2008, were among the most visible symptoms of the Consensus's systemic flaws. Equally telling were the breakdowns of the WTO ministerial meetings in Seattle (1999) and Cancún (2003), which exposed the deepening rift between developed and developing nations – a divide the Doha Round never managed to bridge.

One of the most damaging legacies of the Consensus was its categorical rejection of industrial strategy. Promoted by the BWIs on behalf of industrialised nations, this taboo was reinforced through WTO rules on Trade-Related Investment Measures (TRIMs), intellectual property (TRIPS), and subsidies – all of which



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The Washington Consensus no longer fits a multipolar, digital and fragile world

constrained the policy space for developing countries seeking to nurture domestic industries. Another pillar of WC dogma was deregulation in favour of an idealised “free market”, even in contexts where market institutions were weak or non-existent – as was the case across much of Africa and the least developed countries. For decades, the IMF advanced the notion that inequality was irrelevant so long as growth occurred and would eventually “trickle down”. In practice, however, Structural Adjustment Programmes proved particularly harmful to the poorest nations, which lacked even the minimal institutional foundations upon which the WC's assumptions were built.

Compounding these issues was the manner in which the WC was conceived – largely in western capitals, without meaningful consultation with the developing countries that would bear the brunt of its implementation. The results were mixed enough to invite reappraisal, even during the WC's heyday. Some countries – parts of East Asia, Pinochet's Chile – found ways to combine market openings with strong state direction and industrial strategy. Others – several Latin American cases, some post-Soviet transitions – suffered debt crises, inequality spikes and social backlash.

A loss of faith

The conditionalities imposed by the BWIs and the rigidity of WTO rules led to widespread discontent, manifesting in street protests across the Global South throughout the 1990s and beyond. The backlash against globalisation – whether from the anti-capitalist left in earlier decades or the far right after 2008, with its toxic blend of white supremacy, racism, and anti-immigration sentiment – can be traced, at least in part, to the failures of the WC and the global financial crisis it helped precipitate. Movements such as MAGA and Brexit reflect this disillusionment.

Ironically, none of the countries that successfully industrialised – neither the United States nor Japan before the Second World War, nor South Korea, Taiwan, or Singapore in the post-war era – adhered to the WC's prescriptions during their formative years. Their success was rooted in state-led strategies that prioritised industrial policy, precisely the kind of intervention the “consensus” sought to delegitimise.

The WC may have dominated the late 20th century, but its time has passed. The task now is to craft a new consensus – one that is inclusive, context-sensitive, and responsive to the realities of a multipolar, digital, and ecologically fragile world.

We must revisit the policy mix that enabled the rare post-war success stories – South Korea, Taiwan, and in its own way, China – to ascend into the ranks of advanced economies. This does not mean a wholesale return to 20th-century models, but rather a thoughtful adaptation of

their core principles to contemporary challenges. Education, public health, infrastructure investment, and “infant industry” protection remain as vital today as they were then. But new imperatives – digital trade, climate resilience, and AI governance – demand fresh thinking and innovative frameworks.

We are witnessing two new trends: one, the emergence of a “post-Washington consensus” that insists on public accountability, social safety nets, and the politics of redistribution; the other, the Beijing counter-narrative, where state-led intervention, targeted industrial policy, and limited political liberalisation offer an alternative template.

If the late 20th century was the triumph of liberalisation, the mid-2020s have seen its theatrical undoing in the form of the Trump tariff tempest – sweeping, erratic and punitive. Protectionism is being brandished as an instrument of geopolitics and domestic politics alike. Supply chains are being reconfigured, not so much for efficiency but for dominance and national security. The implicit bargain that underwrote the WC – that free markets would be the engine of prosperity, and supply chains the neutral plumbing of global commerce – has been strained by a revived appetite for economic nationalism, and the wielding of sovereign power as a battle-axe rather than a shield.

Tariffs and industrial subsidies signal a re-politicisation of economic policy. They reveal that Trump's America is willing to accept short-run costs and global friction to reclaim perceived strategic advantage. If in 1990 the default was “liberalise”, in 2025 the default is “what will protect our interests?”

The shattering of a myth

Has the world moved to a new consensus? Not exactly. What has emerged is less a single set of new verities and more an acceptance that policy must be politically context-sensitive. A pragmatic eclecticism now rules: fiscal prudence still matters, but so does targeted public investment; markets are powerful allocators, but they need rules, institutions, and buffers; trade is growth-enhancing, but national security can justify strategic decoupling and politics can justify tariffs.

The neat ideological narrative – liberalise, privatise, deregulate – has given way to a toolbox from which policymakers pick instruments with explicit geopolitical and distributional aims. In that messy landscape, success will come from the hard work of designing policies that fit national capacities, global constraints, and political realities.

That is not the end of globalised liberalisation; it is the end of the myth that there is a ready-made template that every nation subscribes to. The struggle to grow and prosper is still every nation's struggle. But each has to find its own path forward amid the policy mess into which all have been plunged.

The India-Canada turnaround is about deliverables

When the Prime Minister of Canada, Mark Carney, visited India (February 27-March 2, 2026), the bilateral relationship saw a remarkable turnaround, especially in the backdrop of the no-nonsense style ties had taken under his predecessor, Justin Trudeau.

Mr. Carney's visit focused on deliverables and avoided getting bogged down by past issues. The visit also marked the culmination of bilateral efforts to put the relationship back on track, initiated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Kananaskis (Canada) in June 2025 and, also the bilateral meeting in Johannesburg in November 2025. Canada has shown particular pragmatism in tidying over domestic politics to curate its relationship with India carefully, skirting some of the legacy issues.

Spotlight on economic issues

Coming on the back of significant geopolitical churn, the focus on economic issues was unmissable. Canada has faced pressure from its southern neighbour, the United States, which is among its largest trade partners, due to supply chains concentrated toward Washington. U.S. President Donald Trump's tariff policy, together with unending wars in Europe, West Asia, as well as the broader Levant region, have shaken global powers with economic momentum and purpose. India and Canada perhaps fall in the same spectrum of countries which want to avoid war and focus on deliverables for their countries.

However, with global supply chains deeply interconnected, it is virtually impossible for countries to avoid some of the fallout from conflicts and realignments. India and Canada see diversification in trade, energy, investment, and security as essential.



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The Canadian Prime Minister's visit has strengthened India-Canada ties, with a focus on India's needs

The Carney visit resulted in at least eight agreements and contracts, spread over a slew of important sectors. At the top was, of course, the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), for which the terms of agreement have been signed, marking the road map and structure of negotiations.

There was another memorandum of understanding (MoU) under the Australia-Canada-India Technology and Innovation Partnership on cooperation in technology and innovation, designed to support long-term partnership in these areas and enhance Ottawa's engagements with key Indo-Pacific countries.

The focus areas

There were other agreements on augmenting research partnership, cultural exchange, and collaboration in the areas of food and nutrition. Perhaps two of the most significant agreements were the commercial contract between India's Department of Atomic Energy and Canada's Cameco for the supply of uranium ore concentrates, as well as the MoU on critical minerals cooperation.

These areas of cooperation are aligned with the current needs of India, but also a future road map in which technology and critical minerals are indispensable. First, there is a global rush to secure critical mineral supply chains, vital for technology and everyday life in the modern age. Second, supply chains for critical minerals are concentrated in the hands of a few countries, most notably China.

After China showed its ability to leverage critical mineral supply chains – most recently against the U.S. in the face of tariffs imposed by the Trump administration – other nations have

recognised the need to secure their own supply chains that could be affected in times of crises. As such, the bilateral commitments on critical minerals between India and Canada are in sync with the U.S.-led Pax Silica coalition, strengthening strategic cooperation in AI and semiconductors, and which includes India among other 10-odd countries.

Energy at forefront

Among the sectors that India and Canada sought to strengthen, it was energy that took centre stage. Conventional and renewable energy are critical – Canada as a resource-rich nation, and India facing growing demand. For India, growth has to be a function of the usage of clean energy, given its sustainable development goals and zero-emission targets. The fastest way in which India can ensure energy sustainability and predictability is to reduce its reliance on external imports of energy and gradually increase homegrown production of energy. Arguably, the most efficient way to achieve this is by expanding the role of nuclear energy in India's energy mix. India's passing the Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India (SHANTI) Bill, 2025 was seen as a step toward that goal. If the U.S. could be a source country for nuclear reactors, the long-term agreement with Canada for the supply of uranium ore concentrates can add predictability to fuel supply.

Overall, India's dependence on external actors for its energy sources has left it vulnerable in the new era of unending wars. Thus, the uranium deal with Canada is most apt for India in order to reduce external risks, help meet its development goals and also reach its target of achieving 100 GW nuclear power capacity by 2047.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Unbalanced resolution

The UN Security Council resolution against Iran, co-sponsored by India, is a troubling instance of selective outrage in international diplomacy (Inside pages, March 13). The resolution demands restraint from Tehran while remaining conspicuously silent on the far more destabilising actions that preceded it — including the

United States-Israel military strikes and other escalatory acts. Such one-sided censure weakens the credibility of the UN system. By ignoring the chain of events that triggered the crisis, the resolution reduces a complex conflict to a simplistic attribution of blame. India's decision to co-sponsor the measure is puzzling. For decades, New Delhi has prided itself on an

independent foreign policy and a consistent defence of multilateral fairness. Aligning with a resolution that overlooks the conduct of major powers risks diluting that tradition. It also clashes with India's practical interests, as the Strait of Hormuz remains a vulnerable trade chokepoint. **M. Jameel Ahmed**, Mysuru

Let wisdom prevail Continuing tensions between Iran, the United States, and Israel are deeply worrying for the world. Any escalation that drags other nations into the conflict would only multiply human suffering and destabilise the global order. History reminds us that wars ultimately end in dialogue. Therefore, it is imperative that world leaders choose

restraint, diplomacy and peace over prolonged confrontation. **Gopalaswamy J.**, Chennai

Scrutiny and trust

The signal sent by the judicial reaction to ‘corruption’ in the judiciary is troubling. Constitutional institutions command respect through transparency and

accountability, not insulation from criticism. Selective sensitivity risks appearing as insecurity rather than strength. If the judiciary expects trust, it must demonstrate the resilience to face scrutiny, not react to it. **Rushita Avula**, Hyderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

GROUND ZERO



Stranded foreign travellers leave a farmhouse owned by an Indian businessman that has been converted into a shelter in Ajman, near Dubai, UAE. AP

The Indians caught in the crossfire

Since February 28, when Israel and the U.S. jointly attacked Iran, plunging the entire West Asian region into war, thousands of Indian tourists and expatriates have been left stranded across the Gulf. Indian missions have struggled to keep up with requests and demands. From missile and drone strikes, to soaring prices, to communication blackouts, the conflict has left civilians vulnerable, reports **Kallol Bhattacharjee**

Priti Prakash, a travel blogger, had planned a vacation with her family to Dubai, an Instagrammable city of skyscrapers, beach adventures, and pure consumerism in the UAE, months before the war broke out in West Asia. On February 28, she arrived early at New Delhi's international airport to board an Emirates flight scheduled for that afternoon. She was excited to go to the country known as the 'land of endless possibilities'.

Soon after the flight took off, Prakash switched on the in-flight entertainment service. She noticed then that most of her co-passengers were glued not to movies, but to CNN's live coverage of the unfolding situation in the region. Israel and the U.S. had jointly attacked Iran, plunging the region into chaos.

"It was a strange feeling," says Prakash. "The war had broken out when I was busy at security check and immigration."

By the time the aircraft reached the Gulf – an important waterway that is an extension of the Indian Ocean and is bordered by eight countries, including the UAE – Prakash learned that the story had shifted from just Iran to the entire region. It appeared that in retaliation to the attacks by Israel and the U.S., which had killed the Supreme Leader of Iran, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, Iran had hit Qatar, the UAE, and Bahrain, expanding the scope of the war. As a result, Dubai airport, the world's busiest for international travel, with a record 9.23 crore passengers passing through its terminals in 2024, had also become vulnerable. Everyone on board had started praying.

"The pilot announced that the aircraft had been instructed by flight control to stay out of Dubai's airspace," she says. "So, he kept circulating over Oman. After 30-40 minutes of flying aimlessly, we were finally allowed to land in Dubai."

The war had been long in the making. Israel and Iran have shared an acrimonious past that began immediately with the founding of the Islamic Republic in 1979. Decades of bitterness exploded in June 2025 when the two sides exchanged missiles in the so-called 12-day war. The war of 2026, however, has been unprecedented, as Iran's retaliation has followed the lines Tehran had promised during the last conflict, when it warned that any further violation of Iran's sovereignty would draw the entire region into war.

Within the first 24 hours of being attacked, Iran fired missiles and drones at all the U.S. bases located in Jordan, Kuwait, Bahrain, Qatar, the UAE, Saudi Arabia, and Israel. The expatriate community of workers, a vast majority of them blue-collar as well as white-collar professionals from South Asia and Southeast Asia, came within the strike range of missiles and drones from Iran.

Stranded in paradise

After they landed, Prakash and her family frantically began making plans to leave Dubai as soon as possible. By then, the war had already claimed



I visited the Consulate General of India, Dubai, and requested for a meeting with the Consul General to get help and updates. There were 50-70 people at the gate but no one came to help.

PRITI PRAKASH
Traveller

more than 200 lives. This included at least 180 children at a girls' elementary school in Minab, Iran, which had been bombed.

Dubai, considered a human-created paradise, was filled with the sound of sirens. Anxious people spoke of their fears of falling missiles and debris. Prakash cancelled her plans of going sight-seeing and spent most of her time talking to people in the hotel. But planning a way out was difficult: all the flights out had been cancelled. Dubai, an aviation hub, was brought to a standstill as all aircraft had been grounded. Like Prakash, thousands of Indians were stranded in multiple locations in the Gulf.

The UAE government responded with generosity, promising the tourists who were stranded that they would not be thrown out of their hotels. "Hotels received a general order from the government that no one should be thrown out for overstaying," says Prakash. "But when we asked the hotel, the manager told me that that order was specific only to the capital, Abu Dhabi, and did not apply to the rest of the Emirates." She says they had to pay more for the extra two days that they had to spend before returning to India.

Stretched to its limits

According to the Ministry of External Affairs, 90 lakh-1 crore Indian expatriates live and work across the six Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries – Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, the UAE, Qatar, Bahrain, and Oman – constituting the largest foreign workforce in the region. The Indian government issued safety advisories for expatriate workers, but the conflict has also left many Indians travelling in the region for tourism or business, stranded.

Brijmohan Singh Raghuvanshi, a journalist

with Sadhna News, was trapped in the Israeli capital, Tel Aviv. He had arrived in Israel to cover Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit just days before the war. Soon after, the outbreak of the war left him stuck in the country.

"When the Prime Minister's visit ended, we planned to stay a little longer before returning to India. Suddenly, we received emergency alerts asking us to rush to underground bunkers. It came as a surprise," says Raghuvanshi. He adds that despite being a battle-ready state, Israel was jolted this time as Iranian missiles had managed to evade Israel's famed Iron Dome, a multi-mission system capable of intercepting rockets, artillery, mortars, precision-guided munitions, aircraft, helicopters, and unmanned aerial vehicles at ranges of up to 70 kilometres.

"We were hearing the sound of missiles being intercepted in the air. At times, some of the blasts sounded like missiles hitting the ground. But no one would tell us whether these hits were causing casualties as Israel is under a state of emergency," he says. Under such conditions, he explains, it is difficult to get verifiable reports about how the war is affecting the Israeli public. Barring a few handful news outlets such as *Ha'aretz*, most of the mainstream Israeli media has been unable to provide a clear picture of the ground reality. It is foreign workers in Israel who have been posting on social media about the situation.

Police and rescue services were active on the streets, carrying out operations, but Israeli authorities released no casualty figures from the missile strikes, Raghuvanshi says.

Tired of getting no answers to any of his questions, he hired a cab and requested the driver to take him to a spot where some missiles had fallen on the second and third days of the conflict.

"The driver took me to a place where four large buildings had turned into rubble. We saw rescue services on the spot. They claimed that only one person had died. But looking at the extent of the destruction, it seemed highly unlikely that the casualty figure would be that low," he says. Raghuvanshi spoke to residents of the area, who told him that the toll was higher.

He says there was a surge in prices across Israel, which has made life harder for Indian workers and students. The prices of essentials such as water and milk have soared since the fighting began. "A bottle of water cost about 12 shekels (₹350) a few days after the war began," he says.

Ratnadeep Chakraborty, a PhD student at Tel Aviv University, who saw the war in June 2025, is experiencing the current conflict as well. He says he has observed Israel's operations during both. "The war of June 2025 appeared more intense as

it was focused on Israel. This time, there have been fewer hits, but the war is much bigger as the entire region has been plunged into conflict," Chakraborty says over a call. Like Raghuvanshi, he also speaks of the burden of price rise.

The Indian population in Israel has shot up over the past few years, especially after October 7, 2023, when Hamas-led militants poured into southern Israel from Palestine, killing some 1,200 people and abducting 251. Israel reduced the number of Palestinians working in its economy. The rise of Indians is mainly because the Israeli economy is absorbing more Indian workers in the agriculture and construction sectors, where there is a demand for labour. According to the Ministry, the number of Indian blue-collar workers in Israel is around 30,000.

Raghuvanshi says the war has stretched Israel's defence capabilities. On visiting missile impact sites, he found that while Israel may have managed to restrict information about casualties under emergency rules, Israelis have also been victims of the conflict.

Living in stress

The Indian population in Iran is relatively small, concentrated mostly in Qom, Tehran, and Bandar Abbas, the biggest port of the country.

Annie Mirza, who hails from Lucknow, had got caught, along with her mother, in the 12-day missile war last year. She had gone to Iran on a pilgrimage and was in Qom when the war had started. "This year, the war is much bigger as the Rahbar [Ayatollah Khamenei] was assassinated," says Mirza, who is concerned about the wellbeing of her relatives in Kuwait, Qom, and Tehran.

Mirza spent considerable time in Iran last year before being evacuated with the help of the Indian embassy. She says the people of Iran are different from what the western mainstream media portrays. "Iranians are a proud people and they believe in a life of dignity. It is important for them to live with their heads held high," she says.

Her relatives have been unable to contact her often due to an internet outage in Iran and communication restrictions in Kuwait. Kuwait has maintained strong defence ties with the U.S. since its liberation from Iraqi occupation in 1991, but a telecommunications law that gives the government sweeping powers to block content and deny access to the Internet has made staying in touch harder.

"My cousin spoke to me over a WhatsApp call on Thursday (March 12, 2026) and she said the U.S. embassy and the military base were being bombed by Iranian drones from the morning," says Mirza. Her relatives in Kuwait City are living in stressful circumstances as drones and missiles keep hitting the U.S. base, she says.

Providing protection

While there are no reports of Indians getting hurt in the U.S.-Israeli bombing of Iran, the plight of Indian sailors in merchant navy ships and oil tankers is of concern for the Indian government.

So far, five Indians have died in Iranian drone and missile attacks on oil tankers in the Strait of Hormuz and one is missing (presumed to be dead). At least 35-40 have been injured in attacks, officials from the Ministry said, even as India continues to call for an end to strikes on civilian vessels in the region.

Ashish Kumar, who was the captain of the ship *MV SKYLIGHT*, was killed when the ship was targeted by a projectile off the coast of Oman. Kumar and another Indian sailor were initially declared missing. Subsequently, the Ministry announced that he had died in the attack. His family, in Bihar's Bettiah, was informed over email about the circumstances in which he died, but they remain unconvinced that he is no more.

"The government sent us an email saying human remains were found in the captain's cabin. We need further forensic information before believing the news," says Ashish Kumar Verma, Kumar's brother-in-law. Official sources say forensic details about the recovered human remains from the captain's cabin of the ship can be shared only after more official and legal processes are completed in Oman, which is looking into the matter.

While India continues to hold phone calls with the Iranian foreign minister, Seyed Abbas Araghchi, the real worry continues to be the sheer size of the expat Indian population that works in the region, who will face a security threat for as long as the war continues. According to officials, it is not possible to evacuate such a large number of people in a brief span of time.

Prakash says the war seems to have surprised the Indian missions in the region. "I visited the Consulate General of India in Dubai and requested for a meeting with the Consul General to get help and updates. There were 50-70 people at the gate but no one came to help. I tried to contact them on WhatsApp, email, and the helpline numbers, but there was no response," she says.

When she tried to take a photograph of the Indians waiting at the gate, an Indian official forced her to delete it, insisting that she should contact the mission again on email, she says. Despite the prolonged crisis, the expatriate Indian population has not pressed the panic button yet.

This raises the big question of how long the crisis will continue. Zikrur Rahman, former diplomat and a frequent visitor to the Gulf, feels that Iranians are ready for the long haul, while the Arab states in the Gulf are unprepared for any military confrontation with Tehran.

"This war is changing the region. The Americans, who have long provided security for the GCC countries, have proven inadequate," Rahman says. He argues that Israel's September 2025 attack in Doha, Qatar, targeting Hamas's negotiating team, made Arab states doubt the U.S.'s commitment to their security. "They realised the U.S. did not protect them. Now they are paying a heavy price to Iran for hosting U.S. bases."

By the time Indian visitors return for a desert safari next time, the region would have undergone profound security and political changes, he says.



Passengers at the New Delhi international airport after several flights were cancelled due to the conflict, on March 2. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR



OPINION

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{ OUR TAKE }

Beyond the
court rooms

MC Mehta’s PILs led to a radical reformation of India’s environmental jurisprudence

Jurisprudence in India underwent major changes in the wake of the Emergency (1975-77). Public Interest Litigation (PIL) made its appearance in the Supreme Court around this time, promoted by justices PN Bhagwati and VR Krishna Iyer, and became an instrument in the hands of socially conscious lawyers to advocate policy interventions that had either been ignored or escaped the attention of the executive. Since the late 1970s, the Supreme Court has adopted an expansive vision of public interest and has mostly responded favourably to activists compelled to seek an ally in the judiciary to direct the legislature and the executive to act in matters of liberties and rights, which now includes the right to a clean environment.

It is against this backdrop that MC Mehta, in 1985, filed his landmark PIL that, in the course of time and continuous mandamus, transformed environmental jurisprudence in the country and introduced policy guardrails to staunch the assault on the Capital’s air. Mehta’s other PILs led to interventions that saved the Taj Mahal (toxic emissions from industries were causing a discolouring of the marble edifice) and attempted to clean up the Ganga. The right to clean air and water has since become embedded in the right to life, forcing the political class (under the court’s watch) to take action to safeguard urban environments and protect natural resources. Landmark cases such as *Vellore Citizens Welfare Forum* (1996) against pollution from tanneries in Vellore, Tamil Nadu, which saw the Court invoke the polluter pays principle, and the *TN Godavarman Thirumulpad* (1995) on protection of forests, have deepened the notion that industrialisation and development can’t ignore the impact on the environment and citizens’ well-being. The idea of public good has to embrace ecological equity and justice.

Forty years after Mehta first raised his voice for environmental justice, the Supreme Court on Thursday disposed of his PIL, that led to continuous judicial oversight on pollution control in Delhi—from the conversion of the city’s bus fleet to CNG to restrictions on firecrackers and the phasing out of older commercial vehicles. However, the battle has to continue. Mehta’s singular crusade is a great study in the possibilities of civic activism. That it didn’t manage a complete turnaround of Delhi also points to the limitations of volunteerism and judicial activism. Ironically, judicial vigilance has not always been backed or followed up by public action, which may be necessary to demand accountability from the executive. Air pollution continues to be a debilitating threat to life in the National Capital, and despite the Court’s best efforts, progress has been incremental. The same could be said of the pollution in the Yamuna. Thankfully, pollution has now become an important part of public conversation, civic action (including protests), and political mobilisation, even making it to election manifestos and campaigns. The challenge is to translate these into effective policies and implement them in a time-bound manner with provisions to enforce accountability.

Mehta’s PIL led to the constitution of the Environment Pollution (Prevention and Control) Authority (EPCA) in 1998, which submitted regular reports to the Supreme Court regarding Delhi’s environment and pollution. The Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM) replaced EPCA in 2020, but the Court has continued to do its job as a watchdog. The efforts of pioneers like Mehta should not be wasted on account of populist demands (such as relaxing the norms on the use of firecrackers) or misplaced notions of development (the Aravallis case); stricter norms and greater vigilance over compliance are the need of the hour.

{ THIRD EYE }

Barkha Dutt



In West Asia,
the ruins of
globalisation

Donald Trump’s tenure has destroyed the defining principle of globalisation, which is not just about inter-dependence but also integration

US President Donald Trump has lost control of the reckless war he began on Iran. As an Indian whose country has been at the receiving end of the Trump administration’s unstable imperialism, I wish his Iran debacle could allow me some moments of schadenfreude. But alas, I can’t draw any satisfaction from America’s crazed military delusions because of the cataclysmic consequences for our economy, our energy security, and our geopolitical calculations.

You know the numbers by now. Nearly 10 million Indians who live in the Gulf countries have been pulled into a conflict they did not plan for. Forty per cent of India’s crude imports travel through the Strait of Hormuz, a waterway today controlled entirely by the Iranians. And America’s so-called waiver on India’s purchase of Russian oil—for the record, India never stopped buying Russian oil as the White House routinely claims—won’t insulate us from the pain of higher oil prices. This, in turn, will have a spiralling impact on the Indian economy.

If this sounds like the consequences of globalisation, it is the opposite. Trump’s tenure has destroyed the defining principle of globalisation, which is not just inter-dependence but integration. If anything, as cities such as Dubai and Abu Dhabi come under daily drone and missile attacks from Iran, Trump’s war has demolished the idea that in a globalised age, a capitalist oasis can be kept insulated from stormy headwinds of hegemonic powers.

Behaving like a ruthless neo-imperialist,

Trump first dismantled the world trading system with his weaponisation of tariffs. Now, he has gone for the rules of war and strategic partnerships.

Nothing illustrates that better than when a US nuclear submarine sank an Iranian warship in international waters, a couple of weeks after it had been a guest of India at the Milan naval exercises. The precedent set is dangerous and disquieting. Tomorrow, China might send its navy into the Indian Ocean to conduct a military operation of its own.

By all available public accounts, India did the right thing—offering assent for refuge to three Iranian ships within a day and also pressing the Navy into search and rescue when the distress signal was received from IRIS Dena in Colombo. But, it is not as if the Americans informed our Navy of their plans to expand their theatre of operations into the Indian Ocean, off the coast of Sri Lanka. And I am not speaking of operational details here, just the professional courtesy of expanded presence. After all, an Indian vessel could have been in those waters at the same time and found itself caught in an inadvertent crisis.

Not for the first time, Trump’s second term reminds us of the paradox of this Darwinian age. The Americans want to show that might is right.

TRUMP’S IS THE FIRST ADMINISTRATION THAT HAS DONE AWAY WITH THE ENTIRE DICTIONARY OF DIPLOMACY. PERHAPS THIS LEXICON WAS ONLY A VENEER, A PRETENCE, AS CANADIAN PRIME MINISTER MARK CARNEY’S DAVOS SPEECH REMINDED US



In a Trumpian age—and the world may behave in this manner even after he’s gone—there is no better protection than the power of your markets and military.

AFP

And the Iranians, with a staggering instinct for survival, are showing how asymmetric warfare can challenge the most powerful militaries. Their deployment of Shahed drones is the digital age version of guerrilla warfare.

For India, there are lessons on both counts. India’s air defence did a spectacular job in Operation Sindoor. But imagine if the conflict had lasted four weeks instead of four days. Whether to insulate us from short-term security challenges—think drones in the hands of terrorists or their patrons—or focus on long-term growth, India must build hard power. Our democracy, our diversity and pluralism, and our emphasis on constitutional values must remain guiding lights in this marathon journey.

But in a Trumpian age—and the world may behave in this manner even after he’s gone—there is no better protection than the power of your markets and military.

It’s true that Trump is not the first American president to begin irresponsible wars. Right from the 1960s and Kennedy’s foray into Cuba up until the disaster in Afghanistan, regime-change wars have not just failed; they have created more extremist versions of the entities they vowed to displace. Think of ISIS in Iraq or the

return of the Taliban in Afghanistan.

But Trump’s is the first administration that has done away with the entire dictionary of diplomacy. Perhaps this lexicon was only a veneer, a pretence, as Canadian prime minister Mark Carney’s Davos speech reminded us. Even so, it gave the world a common language to conduct business in, a language that was especially helpful in grey zone warfare.

None of this is a brief for the Iranian regime or for that matter for any other authoritarian government. The answer to dictatorships or religious orthodoxy or Neanderthal regimes cannot be wars without an end goal fought by militaries that are unable to place their men and women on the ground. History is littered with proof of this basic working thesis. Nor is war a video game to be spoken of in a language so coarse that the entire claim of being the so-called good guy is in serious question.

So, unless the world comes together to push back against one man’s unbridled and unstable whims, globalisation lies in tatters and it’s each country for itself.

Barkha Dutt is an award-winning journalist and author. The views expressed are personal

Defining moment for law on
passive euthanasia in India

Harish Rana was once a 18 year-old engineering student with the easy confidence of youth and the promise of a long life ahead. A tragic fall from the fourth floor of a building changed everything. Doctors managed to save his life, but not his brain. For the past 13 years, Harish has remained trapped in a body that breathes but does not live. The lives of his parents have been consumed by an exhausting cycle of caregiving, emotional anguish, financial burden and helplessness. This forced his family, and then the courts, to confront one of the most difficult ethical questions of modern medicine: Are we extending his life or merely postponing his inevitable death? What does dignity demand?

The Supreme Court of India has already recognised the right to die with dignity in the landmark *Common Cause* judgment. Yet, the Delhi High Court rejected Harish’s parents’ petition to allow him to pass away. The Court observed that earlier rulings on passive euthanasia largely concerned patients who were kept alive through life-support systems such as ventilators, dialysis or heart-lung machines. Harish, however, was not dependent on such equipment.

The Supreme Court directed the constitution of two independent medical boards to examine his condition. Both boards concluded unequivocally that there was no chance of meaningful neurological recovery.

Still, a difficult legal question remained unre-

solved. Withdrawal of medical support such as a ventilator is one thing; withholding artificial feeding is another. Would withholding feeding amount to active euthanasia? If so, it would be illegal in India.

After a long wait, the judgment was delivered, fortunately, in favour of Harish and his parents.

Harish may soon be gone. But his story will live on in the minds of countless families who face—or may one day face—similar situations caused by devastating neurological injuries, advanced age, or conditions such as Alzheimer’s or terminal illnesses such as cancer.

This case is likely to have a lasting impact on medical ethics and end-of-life decision-making in India. Even today, the Code of Medical Ethics considers euthanasia—except in cases of brain death for organ donation—to be an “unethical act”. In a public interest litigation that I filed before the Bombay High Court, I highlighted this contradiction between evolving constitutional principles and outdated ethical guidelines. In April 2024, the High Court directed the National Medical Commission to examine the issue; yet, those directions have still not been implemented. The Supreme Court’s order in the Harish Rana case will now push medical regulators to adopt a more humane and practical understanding of passive euthanasia.

The case also exposes serious gaps in the implementation of the *Common Cause* guidelines. Harish’s parents must have had to approach the



Nikhil Datar



The Supreme Court of India has already recognised the right to die with dignity in the landmark *Common Cause* judgment.

HT ARCHIVE

courts because they had no practical way to access a medical board. Under the *Common Cause* framework, the responsibility of setting up such boards lies with the hospital in which the patient is admitted. But Harish was being cared for at home.

Furthermore, the guidelines require one doctor on the board to represent the district’s chief medical officer. In my PIL, I had urged the Court to direct the state to create panels of such doctors in every district. Unfortunately, most states have not acted on this requirement.

The *Harish Rana* case also highlights the importance of living wills, or advanced medical directives. A living will is a document in which an individual records his or her wishes regarding medical interventions such as ventilators, dialysis, feeding tubes or other invasive procedures in the event of serious and irreversible illness. Such

directives can guide both doctors and family members when the patient is unable to communicate.

Expecting a healthy 24-year-old Harish to create such a document would have been unrealistic. But, hypothetically, if such a directive had existed, the legal and ethical dilemma might have been far easier to resolve.

After the Supreme Court clarified the law on living wills in 2023, I prepared my own advance directive. Yet I could not find a custodian in Mumbai because the state had not appointed one. Following directions in my PIL, the Maharashtra government finally appointed 413 custodians in March 2024. To my knowledge, very few other states—except Goa—have taken similar steps.

To talk about death remains a taboo in India. Many elders assume their families will automatically make the right decisions when difficult medical questions arise. In reality, such situations often lead to confusion, disagreement, emotional distress and enormous financial strain. Clear written instructions in the form of a living will can spare families this suffering and ensure that the patient’s own wishes remain central.

Without widespread awareness of living wills, reform of medical ethics around end-of-life care, accessible palliative care and an administrative system that allows families to seek timely medical review, the constitutional right to die with dignity will remain largely theoretical.

For 13 years, Harish Rana’s life has been suspended between biology and humanity filled with unimaginable suffering. If this case helps India to speak more openly about death, encourages people to write living wills, and pushes institutions to act with compassion, then Harish’s silent death will leave behind a powerful legacy.

Nikhil Datar is a senior obstetrician-gynaecologist. The views expressed are personal

The national capital’s
other pollution problem

Every winter, air pollution in the national Capital seizes media headlines and social media virality. Beyond short-term measures and individual coping strategies, there are a few clear solutions on the table. Addressing air quality will require sustained policy action over time. What receives very little or no attention in comparison is another form of pollution—noise.

One part of this problem is visible and familiar—traffic and honking. Honking is now deeply embedded in how Delhi drives. Our traffic movement is not rule-based; it is based on negotiation and risk-taking.

There is limited trust that other drivers will behave predictably. Assertion replaces right of way.

In that sense, honking is not just a traffic issue. It reflects how movement takes place in the city—through assertion rather than coordination.

And because honking is ceaseless, it becomes background noise that has come to be accepted.

But traffic is only one part of the soundscape. Delhi is also defined by a continuous cacophony of other sounds—hawkers, music, construction work, loudspeakers, generators, all competing for attention. Even late at night, the city does not fall quiet; it only changes pitch.

Over time, this constant loudness has come to feel normal. It is often explained away as the price of population density,

urban expansion and economic activity. Yet its effect on daily life is rarely examined.

By law, noise in residential neighbourhoods is meant to stay within defined decibel limits. In practice, many parts of Delhi regularly exceed them, often by a wide margin. During peak traffic hours or big events, official monitoring has shown noise levels closer to what one would expect in industrial areas. Despite this, we rarely speak about noise as pollution.

Sustained noise affects how attention works. Constant loudness makes it harder to concentrate for long periods. Over time, people adapt not by filtering noise out, but by paying less attention overall.

The deeper loss is what we stop noticing. Birds in the morning register less, if at all. Moments of quiet become rare enough to feel unusual. The mind remains alert but rarely settled. Over time, this affects how people engage—with work, with public spaces, and with one another.



Rakesh Thukral

Delhi is often described as an aggressive city. That may not be entirely accurate. It feels more like an overstimulated one. In many contexts, volume has become a sign of assertion—of visibility, influence or clout. Quiet is easily mistaken for absence. In such an environment, restraint does not come naturally.

This is not an argument against population density or economic activity. A busy city will never be silent. But there is a difference between activity and constant, and often needless, amplification.

Noise pollution highlights a particular kind of urban challenge—one shaped not only by infrastructure and enforcement, but by everyday behaviour.

Clean air will help the city breathe. Quiet, even in a limited measure, will help it concentrate. Delhi will continue to grow, move, and adapt. The question is whether it can lower its volume—without losing its energy and dynamism.

Rakesh Thukral lives in Delhi and is APAC CEO for Edelman. The views expressed are personal

{ EDITOR’S PICK }

HT’s editors offer a book recommendation every Saturday, which provides history, context, and helps understand recent news events

BOMBS AND GEOPOLITICS

Since its first instance in 1911, aerial bombing has been the defining feature of most wars. This is also true in the ongoing US-Israel war on Iran as well, but with a twist: low-cost drones have entered the picture. While Iran’s drones have effected targeted strikes on US assets in West Asia, a hi-tech American missile killed school children in an Iranian city.

It is in this context that we recommend Sven Lindqvist’s *A History of Bombing*. From the earliest instances of European colonial powers taking this route to subdue popular rebellions in their colonies, Lindqvist outlines a racial impulse in the West that guides such warfare, where civilians are not spared—as targets or collateral. Lindqvist traces the infamous World War II bombings to this reasoning, pointing out that the documented American reluctance to bomb civilians extended only to the West and not to other political geographies.



A History of Bombing
Sven Lindqvist
1999

Hormuz stranglehold and deeper *atmanirbharta*

If there is one piece of advice India must take from Donald Trump, it is ‘drill, baby, drill’



BEYOND IDEOLOGY
R JAGANNATHAN

No matter how the Iran-Israel-US war ends, and no matter how soon it ends, India now has to rethink its energy dependencies — not to speak of dependencies in other areas. In energy, we need deeper *atmanirbharta*, arguably even more than in defence. The ongoing cooking gas shortage, which has become every household’s and restaurant owner’s core short-term concern, tells us why. It can rail politics more than a limited setback even in defence. India’s excess dependency on oil and gas imports should prompt us to not only build larger reserves of the former (and as much of the latter as feasible), but also lead to further geographical diversification. We cannot simply have a 60-65 per cent import dependency in liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), the bulk of which comes from just one

volatile region — West Asia. At the broader energy security level, India has directionally been on the right track. The share of non-fossil fuel power capacity has now crossed 50 per cent of the overall installed capacity of 509 Gw. But the problem relates to concentrated dependence on some regions driven by policy priorities. The growing dependence on West Asia for gas supplies is directly related to the huge expansion in household cooking gas consumption and the increasing use of gas in the transport sector. As Shamika Ravi, a member of the Economic Advisory Council of the Prime Minister, noted in a post on social media site X (formerly Twitter), “Indian households now depend on petroleum products for both cooking (LPG) and transport...Together, LPG + conveyance account for 7.5-10.2 per cent of monthly budgets. This makes our households doubly exposed to any oil supply disruption — a vulnerability that did not exist at this scale in 2011, when rural LPG adoption was just 17 per cent and conveyance 4.2 per cent.” While trying to address pollution and climate change, we may have given less importance to domestic production of fossil fuels, which are going to be important over the next

two decades, coinciding with the period when India must maximise its demographic dividend. There is no place for fossil fuel complacency, never mind what climate activists and greens tell you. If there is one piece of advice we must take from Donald Trump, it is this: “Drill, baby, drill”. It means more and faster exploration and production investments. What we must also thank Mr Trump for is exposing our vulnerabilities. Our dependence on West Asia, especially those supply sources that are routed through the Strait of Hormuz, cannot sustain. The major West Asian oil and gas producing countries are on either side of the narrow shipping waterway leading to the Strait, but they are now subject to Iran’s security priorities. Bahrain, Qatar, Oman, the UAE and even Saudi Arabia have most of their production going through the Strait of Hormuz. In the 15th century, the Portuguese realised that the trade in spices and other goods from India was subject to extortion by West Asian and Venetian merchants, and Vasco da Gama was commissioned by Manuel I of Portugal to find a new sea route to India. While Vasco da Gama is not a revered name in post-colonial Indian history, he did find a different route to India via the Cape



ILLUSTRATION: BINAY SINHA

of Good Hope. This is our challenge if we choose to tap into West Asian fossil fuels — finding a new route that avoids the Strait of Hormuz. India’s proposal for the IMEC corridor (India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor) involves building transport infrastructure going through the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Jordan, Israel, and Greece. Some of these countries are going to be under Iranian threat, which may make the corridor unviable unless there is a wider peace deal in West Asia, where both Israel and Iran agree to back off

from threatening the other. Iran needs to do more, since its theocracy has put Jew-hatred and a commitment to destroy Israel at the core of its wider Islamist mission, which includes supporting proxies in Lebanon (Hezbollah), Yemen (Houthis) and Gaza (Hamas). More than stopping Iran’s nuclear ambitions, it is these ever-present threats to Israel’s borders that need reining in — and only Iran can do that. Israel and the US have not helped matters by decapitating the Iranian leadership, making the successor regime’s will-

ingness to do a deal more unlikely. The IMEC is not going to work in the foreseeable future. We need different sources to fill in whenever supply disruptions hit the Strait of Hormuz. Dependence on West Asia is only a fair-weather option for us. Whenever peace reigns, we can use this region to augment or stock up reserves at low prices. Over the medium term, we must ask Qatar, the UAE, and Saudi Arabia to build shipping capabilities far away from the Strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea areas that the Houthis can target. And, of course, we must fast-track domestic exploration and production of oil and gas, especially the recent discoveries off the Andamans. We should also be fast-tracking the use of ethanol for cooking purposes, using appropriate stoves. However, it is not only in energy that we must reduce over-dependence on a few sources of supply in troubled parts of the world. This should be our guiding philosophy in all critical areas, both in imports and exports. Three areas, apart from energy, stand out. One is our over-dependence on Chinese supplies in everything from rare earths to electronic components and other things. Production-linked incentives are important, but ease of doing busi-

ness is even more vital. Two, our software services are too focused on North America, the US in particular. But margins aren’t everything. The Infys, TCSes and Wipros must be prodded to diversify markets over a 10-year period. Their share of non-American and domestic Indian business must grow substantially, and products and sovereign platforms must be a larger share of their business. Our dependence on foreign tech platforms — from Google to Microsoft, Meta and X — is a strategic vulnerability, not least because these firms are heavily involved in the US’ national security architecture. If they had to choose between following Indian interests and American ones, no prizes for guessing which way they will tilt. We must have our own sovereign email, messaging, social media platforms, artificial intelligence models, office and Cloud services that will counterbalance US Big Tech. Our data should not be shareable with Uncle Sam, unless when authorised by Indian courts. A sobering thought: *Atmanirbharta* is not without costs. There will be higher costs, and slimmer margins. That, unfortunately, is the price for strategic autonomy. The author is a senior journalist

Bihar after Nitish Kumar



PLAIN POLITICS
ADITI PHADNIS

“I have a Rashtriya Swayams-evak background. Nitishji is not from our sangathan (organisation). But he has surpassed many of us when it comes to sacrifice, integrity, and dedication to social justice,” said a Bharatiya Janata Party MLA, a Dalit, from Bihar. But there are other views. “We admire Nitishji. But we also want modernisation and development in Bihar. Whenever we would discuss industrialisation and land, he would always hold us back. His observation always was: If you take land away from the farmer, what will he do for a living? If Bihar is among the bottom three states in India in urbanisation, the blame must go to him. It was deeply frustrating,” a former minister in the Bihar government and now a top office-bearer in the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) told *Business Standard*. Now that Nitish Kumar, in his last days as Bihar chief minister, is out of the state equation and the BJP will be the primary decision-maker in the government as the single-largest party with 89 of the 243 seats in the Assembly, it is worth considering what Bihar could look like in the years to come — and whether Mr Kumar’s development perspective of the state will be shared by the BJP. There’s no denying the facts. The latest data from the NITI Aayog (2025) and Bihar government (Economic Survey, 2025) shows that as of 2022-23, the working popula-

tion in Bihar was concentrated in agriculture, forestry, and fishing (49.6 per cent); services (28.9 per cent); and, construction sectors (18.4 per cent). Just 5.7 per cent were employed in manufacturing. The state’s redemption could be its massive infrastructure investment in the past few years: ₹33,000 crore in highway upgrade offered by the central government, ₹1 trillion in ongoing rail capacity projects, and improvement in district roads and more. The dilemma is: What should Bihar do with all this infrastructure? Should it seek accelerated industrial investment, requiring extensive (and expensive) land acquisition, and ending in only minimal additional employment? Or should it encourage the creation of industrial estates in which small and medium units can be set up, like, say, the Hajipur Industrial Area? After agriculture, micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) generate the maximum employment. Ninety-five per cent of Bihar’s all industrial units and 65 per cent of manufacturing output are from MSMEs. In 2023 [when the Janata Dal (United), or JD(U), again became an ally of the Rashtriya Janata Dal], the Department of Industries in Bihar made a strong appeal to the Centre with a strategic business plan in which it argued that access to credit and market linkages were the two biggest challenges for MSMEs. The response to the plea for help was below expectations, officials say. The chief minister had the wrong sort of alliance partners. When the partners changed, the BJP’s Nitish Mishra, viewed by the state’s industry as its champion, was made minister. However, he did not figure in the 2025 Nitish Kumar government because the BJP bowed to caste dynamics and

opted to excise a Brahmin from Madhubani from its list. All this suggests that if the BJP is to combine industrialisation and urbanisation in Bihar with social justice, its champions and advocacy leaders have to be from the same social base. For the BJP, this is an existential choice. Its opposition to the state government’s caste census tells its own story. And then, there’s the other choice, which too is deeply problematic. In 2022, when the BJP and JD(U) were partners, Mr Kumar publicly snubbed the BJP’s call to follow the Yogi Adityanath model, at work in Uttar Pradesh, and get all loudspeakers down from masjids. “Let us not talk about this nonsense. In Bihar, we do not interfere in the religious practices of any people. Every person in Bihar has the full right to follow their own faith,” he said at a public meeting in Purnea with BJP colleague Shahnawaz Hus-sain on the stage. This was not a random act. BJP old-timers recall many occasions when he stood up to the BJP while being its ally. At the same time, he supported the BJP’s Waqf legislation and said absolutely nothing about the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. His party contested the 2019 and 2024 Lok Sabha elections in alliance with the BJP and got 6 per cent and 12 per cent, of the Muslim vote, respectively. The data suggests that so long as it has the JD(U) by its side, the BJP can eat its Muslim cake and have it too. No one can say if this will still be the case if Mr Kumar is no longer on the scene. So, the key question is: In his absence, will the BJP become more like the JD(U)? Or will the JD(U) become more like the BJP? The Opposition is asking itself the same question.

Where 2 billion voters reside

Rating democracies is a tricky business. I am only using the simple metric of who in the Indian subcontinent has had the most peaceful, stable, normal political transitions and continuity

Try as we might, we will not find another continuous region in the world where about two billion people vote and value democracy. Not in the Americas, not Africa. Europe doesn’t have the numbers, and most of Eastern Asia has the 1.4-billion Chinese overhang. Something makes the Indian subcontinent different. All of its nations, from the Maldives through Sri Lanka, India, Nepal, Bangladesh and Bhutan have regular elections. Of course, the quality of democracy varies, let’s say, from Pakistan at the lowest rung to India. It isn’t my case that Indian democracy is perfect. Rating democracies is a tricky business. I am only using the simple metric of who’s had the most peaceful, stable, normal political transitions and continuity. India has had the most of it, barring the 19-month aberration of the Emergency that delayed an election by a year. Pakistan, we rate as the lowest on this scale, as it discovered elections more than 25 years after its creation, and even then has never had an elected Prime Minister complete a full term. It has always ceded much ground to the army and invented its own hybrid arrangement. It has also had many full military interregnums for long periods, such as General Musharraf from 1999 to 2008. Yet, people continue voting. Look elsewhere now. In a tiny, ultra-stable Himalayan monarchy like Bhutan, the king has been farsighted enough to hold regular elections and pass much power on to the Prime Minister and the Cabinet so installed. Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka and the Maldives (listed in order of their population size) have all been having elections and stable, peaceful transitions. Nowhere has that dreaded “A” word, for the army, cropped up. Not even in Bangladesh for three decades despite its history of two military dictatorships. Commitment to elected democracy, therefore, is well-established among one-fourth of humankind, living in one geographically cohesive subcontinent. If anything, in all countries except Pakistan, the army has proved to be a force for good, backstopping stability for fresh elections and transition — even when an established government was swept away dramatically by a furious street protest. In the past four years, we have seen this play out among three of these neighbours. Sri Lanka’s Mahinda Rajapaksa fell first, then Sheikh Hasina Wazed in Bangladesh, and then Khadga Prasad Sharma Oli in Nepal. All three, after what looked like a disruption to rival the Arab Spring, did not collapse into anarchy. They sprang back on their feet,

held clean, peaceful elections and elected popular leaders with wide majority. Two of those, Sri Lanka and Nepal, in the process also discovered new political parties. There was anger with the “system”. It is just that it became a fury against the established political party instead: They are all the same, equally bad, complicit. The answer wasn’t a new non-constitutional force or a new constitution, but a new political party. Nepal is the latest. Over two dramatic days between September 8 and 9 in 2025, the Oli government fell amid speculation on “what the army would do”. It did nothing. It just maintained order so a transitional government under a respected Chief Justice (Nepal’s first woman Chief Justice) Sushila Karki was set up with the solitary agenda of holding a peaceful and fair election soon. She delivered it within six months and allowed all parties to contest freely. The results were a spectacular rejection of all those between whom 14 prime ministries had changed hands since the end of the monarchy, the establishment of democracy, and the adoption of a republican constitution in 2008. This marked the end of the Maoist power. Now, with a shade less than 10 per cent in the 165-directly elected house, they’ve been swept away to the garbage heap of democratic history. The new leader? Balendra Shah, just 35, and not in the job because he’s the offspring of a famous parent. A structural engineering MTech from Belagavi’s Visvesvaraya Technological University (VTU), he was a rapper who became a humongous cult figure, with his lyrics reflecting popular frustrations against corruption, lousy governance, desperate outward migration and the quality of life. The party he joined, the Rastriya Swatantra Party, was launched by journalist Rabi Lamichhane in 2022 and has now won one short of a two-thirds majority. At this moment, it even looks ideology-free, although it calls itself centrist. The nut-graf of the story is a complete trust in the constitution, the democratic process, and the fact that all key institutions — from the Supreme Court, Presidency, and Election Commission to the Army — stayed intact, retaining their stature and respect. Bangladesh played out just a little bit earlier, and had its variations. The supposed caretaker government under Muhammad Yunus didn’t quite act like one and pretended as if it was fully mandated to make policy shifts, including reversals. It was the army chief who nudged Mr Yunus back into reality. The election was far from ideal as one major party, the Awami League was banned. However, the elec-



NATIONAL INTEREST
SHEKHAR GUPTA

tion finally was peaceful — way more peaceful than any we remember in our West Bengal — and Tarique Rahman (60) won a two-thirds majority. Almost immediately, we have seen some return to sanity. The anti-India rhetoric and activity is down, conversations re-established, and the new government is looking at Bangladesh’s future rather than grievances, national or personal, of the past. Bangladesh’s democracy has emerged stronger even if the Awami League ban remains a blot. Sri Lanka before that went through a longer, but remarkably calm process. Initially, while the rest of the Rajapaksa family left, Gotabaya, as President, appointed the old UNP (United National Party) stalwart Ranil Wickremesinghe as Prime Minister. Two months later, the popular protest, called Aragalaya (the struggle), also threw Gotabaya out, and Wickremesinghe was made President. This, when his party only had one MP. The secret ballot in the national parliament chose to continue with him. Why? Because they had faith in their Constitution, democracy, and a shared commitment to stability in the national interest. The election was held entirely peacefully in November 2024, where Anura Kumara Dissanayake (57), a committed communist formerly from the Janatha Vimukthi Peramuna (JVP), which was once considered a terrorist organisation and violently suppressed, swept aside all the established parties to win a two-thirds majority. To this extent, this was a pattern of rejecting all legacy parties that Nepal followed. The only difference being that one gave a landslide to the hard Left (Sri Lanka) and the other (Nepal) rejected it sweepingly. The Maldives has also had peaceful, electoral transitions since 2008, although the odd incoming leader may have jailed his predecessor. We told you there is no such thing as a perfect democracy. Early on, we also listed Pakistan among these democracies and that’s only because the country is now going through its longest continuous phase of elected governments, such as they may be. Within its hybrid history, the current arrangement has produced the weakest government and it has conspired with the army to mutilate the Constitution. So here’s the question: How come, while all other countries in the subcontinent have seen their democracy mature and strengthen, Pakistan has slipped? The answer many say is in the way each has imagined its nationalism. Pakistan is exceptional in that it is still fighting to justify the two-nation theory. It is this fixation that has never allowed any institution except the army to build moral stature. This happens when you define yourselves ideologically as a national security state. The Pakistan predicament is existential. Existential not in the sense that it’s commonly used these days, but in the sense closer to the original Jean-Paul Sartre: Why do I exist? And how do I exist? Therein lies the difference between the quality of its democracy and the rest of the subcontinent’s two billion. By special arrangement with *ThePrint*

When bots buy and humans consume



YES, BUT...
SANDEEP GOVAL

Artificial intelligence is not tweaking marketing. It is quietly rearranging its foundations. There are two revolutions underway. Most marketers are busy reacting to the first. Almost none seem prepared for the second. And few appear to be even trying to prepare. The first revolution is visible.

Consumers are no longer “searching”. They are “asking”. For 20 years, we have optimised for Google. Keywords, backlinks, metadata — the holy trinity of digital marketing. The ritual was predictable: Search, click, compare and convert. Traffic flowed like clockwork. Unfortunately now, whether we like it or not, that flow is ebbing. Ask a chatbot for “the best laptop under ₹1.5 lakh” and you don’t get 10 blue links. You get three answers. Curated. Summarised. Sanitised. Your beautifully designed website may never even be visited. Your search engine optimisation or SEO budget may never see daylight. Kaput. Web traffic erosion today is not merely theoretical — it is structural. The game has shifted from SEO to what we now call generative engine presence. Visibility now depends not

on how well you rank, but on how well you are synthesised. Brands built purely on information are vulnerable. Information can be summarised. It can be abstracted. It can be replaced. Brands built on community, emotion, and experience are harder to displace. Nobody visits Reddit for information alone. They go for belonging. AI cannot replicate that — at least not yet. But here is the second revolution. And this one is deeper. We are accustomed, in today’s context, to asking, “Who is the customer?” We have to now begin asking, “What is the customer?” When AI agents start evaluating options, comparing specifications, filtering bias, negotiating price and completing transactions — the buyer may not be human at all. The consumer remains human. But the decision-maker could well be

an algorithm. This is not science fiction any longer. The infrastructure is already being built. And rapidly. Every minute. Imagine telling your assistant, “Order me the best air purifier under ₹20,000 with high energy efficiency and low maintenance.” You do not browse. You do not click. You do not read reviews. The entire purchase journey happens inside a machine. Now ask yourself: Is your brand optimised for a human emotion — or for a machine evaluation? And that is the catch few brand handlers understand today. Websites are currently built for eyeballs. Scrolls. Clicks. Hoverstates. AI agents, on the other hand, prefer structured data, clean specifications, transparent pricing and credible signals. We spent decades understanding human psychology — cognitive

biases, social proof, framing effects. Tomorrow we will need to understand machine logic. Algorithms have their own biases. They penalise overt commercial influence. They weigh ratings differently. They respond inconsistently across models. Marketing will not disappear. It will bifurcate. One layer will continue speaking to human aspiration — storytelling, identity, community. The other layer will quietly speak to machine evaluation — clarity, structure, verifiability. And then comes the strategic question that Indian CEOs must confront. If AI becomes the primary digital interface — who owns the relationship? The intelligence layer, or the brand behind it? From a legal standpoint — let us momentarily wear a lawyer’s hat —

this is not an abstract concern. It is about data ownership, contractual boundaries, liability frameworks, and control over customer interfaces. If AI intermediates discovery and purchase, the platform providing that intelligence could sit between brand and consumer. And, that is a structural risk. The companies that will win are those that ensure AI remains an enabler — not an owner — of customer relationships. Contracts must, therefore, preserve data rights. Brand voice must not be diluted into generic responses. Brand experience cannot, and must not, be outsourced to an invisible layer. India has a unique advantage here. We are not a peripheral market. We are a linguistic labyrinth. If AI can function seamlessly across Hindi, Tamil, Marathi, Bengali, Bhojpuri

and dozens more — it will have learned something profound about contextual intelligence. India is not merely deploying global AI. It is pressure-testing it. Stretching it. Civilising it for cultural complexity. Which means we are not just users. We are co-authors. Marketing has survived print-to-broadcast, broadcast-to-digital, desktop-to-mobile. Each shift created winners and casualties. This one goes further. It does not merely change the channel. It changes the decision-maker. Yes, AI is upending marketing. But the real upheaval is this: The future customer may not blink. May not feel. May not be persuaded by nostalgia. And yet, paradoxically, the brands that will thrive are those that double down on the one thing machines cannot manufacture — meaning. AI isn’t just upending marketing: It’s rewriting who the customer is. The author is chairman of Rediffusion



With colonialism came the decline of Persian



PAST PARTICIPLE
MANU S PILLAI

In 1656 a senior courtier of the sultan of Golconda defected to the Mughals. Titled Mir Jumla, this Persian emigre was one of India's wealthiest, most powerful men: he lent money to English traders on the coast, owned a merchant fleet of his own, controlled the kingdom's diamond mines, possessed an army, and above all, steered the sultan's government. It was a phenomenal achievement for an immigrant who had begun life as a shoe-salesman. So phenomenal, in fact, that eventually, the sultan smelled a threat. Salacious gossip—for instance, that Mir Jumla had taken a tumble in bed with the queen-mother—did not help. With things at a risky impasse, the minister chose to flee. But in the process the Persian also carted off to the Mughals a massive diamond, believed by some to be the Kohinoor—a gem that, less than a century later, another Persian, Nadir Shah, would seize for himself.

India's links to Persia—much discussed in the context of the ongoing war in Iran—are old and fascinating. In the medieval Deccan, for instance, Persianate culture was fashionable, in the same way that American soft power prevails in our time. Local Muslim kings, therefore, actively sought to cultivate it. One Bahmani sultan, for instance, nearly

wooed the poet Hafiz to India, while another imported Persian scholars, warriors, architects, artists and other professionals by the shipload.

At a certain level, this sparked remarkable interactions. Bijapur's Adil Shahi dynasty, to cite one, was founded by a Persian warrior and his Hindu queen. Equally, however, it resulted in hostilities between local grandees and the foreign-born nobility. Around 1470, a Russian traveller was astonished that the Deccan's ruling class seemed overwhelmingly Persian, and the Bahmani state was soon torn up by a sons-of-the-soil-versus-immigrants type of conflict.

Interestingly, while the Mughals occupy much imperial real estate in our imagination, the Shah of Persia also had some sway in India. For the Deccan sultanates looked not to Delhi but Isfahan for protection, openly declaring themselves its vassals. This flirtation was strategic: an insurance policy against the Mughals. But faith was a factor too.

Many of the Deccan's princes were Shia Muslims. Indeed, the rulers of Ahmednagar (descended from a converted Brahmin, funnily enough) routinely sent their bodies to be buried in Persian-held Karbala. In the early 1600s, there was talk of a marriage alliance between Shah Abbas and a Golconda princess (who'd have introduced some Telugu blood into the Safavid dynasty had the union materialised), while some decades later begums from that kingdom travelled to pay their respects to Shah Safi. Such advertisements of loyalty to Persia didn't pan out in the end, though, for the Mughals swallowed up the sultanates. Interestingly the emperor who achieved this,



Bijapur's Adil Shahi dynasty was founded by a Persian warrior and his Hindu queen.

Aurangzeb, had an Iranian mother.

But Persianate influence was not limited to Muslim courts, even if it was most pronounced in those settings. Architecture in Vijayanagara featured Persian flourishes, for example, and the court's sartorial styles also absorbed foreign inspiration. The conical *kullah* hat

became here, thus, the *kullayi*, or, in everyday Kannada, *kulavi*. Murals at Tirupudaimarudur and Lepakshi depict Hindu lords also sporting a tunic, the *kabayi*—an Indianisation of the Persian *qaba*. To be clear, embracing foreign fashion trends does not suggest a wholesale acceptance of Persianate political

ideology or power. Krishnadevaraya, for instance, wore the *kullayi*. But in his poetry, he also delights at crushing the heads of Persians "like melons", and of filling (proverbial) tanks with their blood. It is a little bit like present-day supporters of the Iranian regime. They may wear trousers and shirts, and yet rail against the West—in English.

Language, in fact, is another area where Iranian influences left a mark. On the one hand, under the powerful Muslim-ruled empires of the subcontinent, Persian itself became the lingua franca for transregional diplomacy and politics—a lot like the place English holds in our time, with its advantages and exclusions both. As late as the 1820s, therefore, Malayali royals writing to the British in Bengal did so not in their mother-tongue or the colonisers language, but in Persian.

Equally, however, just as the legitimacy of English is questioned, Persian too had its critics. In a 14th century Vijayanagara poem, the "screeching of owls" is preferred to this language. Three-hundred years later, the Maratha hero Shivaji sought to replace "overvalued Yavana words" with Sanskrit. The project's practical success was limited: later Maratha rulers were known by the Persian title, Peshwa. Why, the surname of the incumbent Maharashtra chief minister (Fadnavis) too has Persian roots.

As odd as it may seem to us today, "during the early modern period," to quote Arthur Dudley, "India—even compared with Iran—was arguably the world's main centre for the patronage of Persian literature and scholarship." Many took to the language for better employment but there was genuine

passion too. One of the "great Persian prose stylists and poets" of the 17th century, thus, was a man called Chander Bhan, who proudly also flaunted his Brahmin roots. Translation of Sanskrit texts into Persian had their own impact, including in ways that might surprise us now. In the 1860s, for example, Kanhaiyalal Alakhdhari translated 52 Upanishads into Urdu, to popularise among Hindus their textual and philosophical traditions. Except that with Sanskrit sealed off from most, his work was based on the *Sirr-i-Akbar*—a Persian treatise on the Upanishads, made by a Mughal prince, Dara Shukoh.

The decline of Persian—and Persianate culture—coincided with the rise of colonialism in the country. People seeking upward mobility now began to prefer English to the old court language, while in dress and other respects too, Anglicisation became attractive. One exemplification of this new trend appears in portraits of a single figure. The Travancore rajah Uthram Tirunal (reigned 1846-60), like several of his ancestors, sat for portraits dressed in Persian robes. But towards the end of his rule, he did something unusual: he asked a durbar painter to depict him in the Englishman's garb, resulting in perhaps among the earliest images of an Indian man in Western attire. His predecessor had already switched Persian with English when corresponding with the British. This transition to the white man's clothes, however, confirmed something more sharply: the advent of a new age, and the passing of another.

Manu S. Pillai is a historian and author, most recently, of *Gods, Guns and Missionaries*.

How the French challenged the British in India

Instead of zooming in on specifics, Robert Ivermee's book on French colonialism in India tries to be many things all at once

Rohit Chakraborty

To the untrained eye, the remains of a former French establishment look puny on the map of modern India: a bit of land along the rim of the Bay of Bengal, like Chandannagar, and Puducherry on the Coromandel Coast; then yonder west, a stronghold in Mahé on the Malabar Coast. So sparse, compared to the British, it seems, that some would think the French were merely passing through. Not quite as expansive and invasive as the Raj, or even as pioneering as the Portuguese, who sliced the Indian Ocean to inaugurate a trade route with South and South-East Asia as early as 1498, the French remain just a rung above the Dutch, the most minuscule of the Europeans in India (the Danes barely register).

So, how did the relatively small French colony in India become the principal challenger to the mighty British presence? How did the French become middle managers to Versailles on one end and India's indigenous rulers on the other as they negotiated France's mercantile ambitions? Why did they build alliances with, and sometimes double-cross, local resistance to English dominion? How did they try to recoup frequent, often colossal financial losses of the Compagnie des Indes Orientales (dissolved, bankrupted, and later revamped by a Scotsman, John Law, as Compagnie perpétuelle des Indes)? To sate the French gap in canonical histories of European colonisation on the Indian subcontinent, Robert Ivermee offers *Glorious Failure: The Forgotten History of French Imperialism in India*. France is no more chopped liver.

Ivermee's condensed history is a tightly stacked relay of epochs. It is a bird's-eye view of the history of French colonisation in India that is at times illuminating, but, mostly, a relentless rehearsal of history that moves at breakneck speed.

The French arrived about a century after the establishment of the Estado Português da Índia in 1505 and found the ports of Cochin (now Kochi) and Goa not only peppered with mimeries of European architecture, but also the Portuguese stronghold in the subcontinent



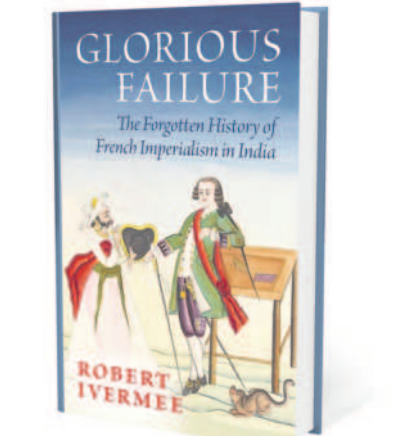
beginning to come slowly undone.

Ivermee begins his survey with François Pyrard de Laval, who arrived in Chittagong after a tumultuous few years of imprisonment in the Maldives, travelled westwards, and spent a few months in the court of Calicut's Zamorin. Ivermee uses the French navigator's arrival as his locus to build a constellation of France's vested interests in regions surrounding the Indian Ocean, specifically trade in (and with) Madagascar and later Mauritius, regions skirting the Persian Gulf, Ceylon, Indonesia, in addition to investments in the Caribbean and North America that France was beginning to foster.

What follows could very well be Ivermee's portrait of Puducherry: its creation, its consolidation, the tugs-of-war it endured, its transfers of power and, at the very core of this, the figure canonical to the history of both the region, and to the shadow of the French empire in India: Joseph François Dupleix, who became the governor of Puducherry and French India, after 12 years of governorship of Chandannagar.

Ivermee's *Glorious Failure* is many things at once. It is a survey of globally intertwined histories of French trade. It is an assemblage of miniature biographies: of Law, John-Baptiste Colbert (who launched the Compagnie in 1664) and Dupleix, of course, but also of key Indian players to the French consolidation, like Ananda Ranga Pillai, who was Dupleix's chief courtier and kept a journal that offers a peek into Dupleix's day-to-day; Muzaffar Jang, the nizam of Hyderabad

(above) Basilica of the Sacred Heart of Jesus church in Puducherry; and the statue of Joseph Francois Dupleix, the governor of Puducherry and French India.



Glorious Failure: The Forgotten History of French Imperialism in India: By Robert Ivermee, 384 pages, Context, ₹699.



who was an ally to the French; and, of course, Hyder Ali and Tipu Sultan, who had inconsistent French support across their military and imperial careers. It is a critique of the economic fallacies of the Compagnie and missionary malpractices of the Jesuits in particular and Catholics in general. It is a dramatisation of inchoate French-Indian allyship against the British.

Glorious Failure is not, however, an entirely immersive history of French India. Ivermee has tried to pack a multi-epoch history of French presence in the subcontinent into the space allowed to a midlist novel. This overpacked history infuses his writing with a staccato tempo.

In the span of only two pages, for instance, Ivermee skips from the Mughal-Maratha war's arrival in Puducherry in 1690 to a character vignette of Rajaram Bhosle, the Maratha empire's third Chhatrapati, to Franco-Dutch hostilities and the Nine Years' War, to French colonial stakes in America and the West Indies.

This engorged scale, along with the multinational coordinates, makes Ivermee's prose flit here then there. It detracts. It distracts. It overwhelms. If this is, in fact, the premier text on French India to exist recently, why does it disappoint? Precisely because it tries to be many things at once. Very early in the narrative, it loses its essence, its thesis, even.

To understand and even remind myself why Ivermee is recounting this history in the first place, I had to return to the blurb, which speaks of his aim to contest the "myth of a benign French presence on the subcontinent." The French are often projected as the lesser of the European aggressors, relative, especially, to the British. If they truly were agents of appropriation, trafficking and assault, Ivermee concedes a recurrent use of potent declarative gestures for his readers that tie his narrative back to his thesis.

These callbacks could have helped signpost his challenge to a popularly conceived notion that French colonialism was merely a quirk in the annals of India: a cosmetic blip exemplified in Puducherry's *ville blanche* (White Town), for instance. What Ivermee unearths out of the usual practice of fetishising the architectural, literary, culinary, theological and other cultural metonyms in both Indic and global imaginations of India's French colony is the inconsistency of French allyship and, at times, the failed narrative of some syncretism.

Perhaps one of the more scintillating passages that undoes a notion of the French as an exotic western presence in India is one where Ivermee implicates France in the slave trade. Far from a simple outpost of Compagnie activities, the subcontinent often became the source and destination in slave trade routes. Even before any European engagement, the Indian Ocean was the playground of Persian, Arab, and Swahili slavers.

With the Estado, the Portuguese set a traffic of slaves between Mozambique and India, and farther east, in South-East Asia. South Asian slaves were even shipped towards Mexico in the western hemisphere and the Philippines closer to home. The Dutch expanded this network to distribute South Asian labour to Java, Malacca, Cape Colony, and elsewhere. The British established Madras (now Chennai) and Bombay (now Mumbai) as the premier sites for buying and selling South-Asian slaves to ship to South-East Asia.

When the French entered this market, out went the "*principe du sol fibre*" (freedom principle) that would have emancipated all those enslaved when they landed on French soil. This was done to serve the interests of the Compagnie, of course. Out came Colbert's Code Noir (or Black Code),

justifying slavery for business.

Ivermee showcases quite brilliantly how it was possible for France to set up shop in India due to their human trafficking schemes in Senegal and Guinea that helped sustain the North American and Caribbean colonies. Whilst showcasing how slave trade across the Indian Ocean is often a minor focus in histories of slave trade routes, which frequently centre the transatlantic and Pacific pathways, Ivermee uses French colonialism to explain that these routes have historically nourished one another.

Oddly, these examples that should upend and complicate sunny perceptions of India's French postings are buried in Ivermee's prose, which is peppered with non-sequiturs. Now, these detours that he takes are essential for setting the context for those uninitiated in French maritime and colonial histories, but they do a disservice in the end, leaving no room for Ivermee's story to breathe.

Could Ivermee have approached this flawed bird's-eye perspective differently? There is a wealth of South-Asianists who are reviving and revising history with apertures rather than panoramas, a methodology where the former often leads to the latter, and is kinder to the pace of the narrative, and to the reader. I am thinking of great character sketches, like those of Ruby Lal, and geo-dynastic biographies, like those of Anirudh Kanisetti.

There is an anxiety to the scope of *Glorious Failure*, of covering enough, rather all ground, and there is also a kind of audacity in it that is admirable. Despite, or perhaps because of, the ambitious vastness, which makes Ivermee's prose erratic, readers who come to his book seeking a primer on India's French history and legacy may be standing on a cracked foundation.

Rohit Chakraborty is a scholar and critic from Guwahati. They live in Kolkata.



CHARTERED PLANE LEAVES KOCHI WITH SOME IRAN SAILORS, BODIES OF OTHERS KILLED IN U.S. ATTACK NEAR SRI LANKA

Will try our best: Iran envoy on safe passage for India-bound fuel ships

Two LPG tankers are reported to be transiting Strait of Hormuz

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, March 13

SIGNALLING HEADWAY in Delhi's efforts to persuade Tehran to let India-bound fuel ships transit the Strait of Hormuz, Mohammad Fathali, Iran's Ambassador to India, said Friday "we will try our best to remove the problems" and "I think you can expect good news in the near future".



Mohammad Fathali (right), Iran's envoy to India, and Abdul Majid Hakeem Ilahi, Supreme Leader's representative, in New Delhi. ANI

2 INDIANS KILLED AS DOWNED DRONE FALLS IN OMAN CITY P 6

The Reuters news agency reported that Iran had allowed two Indian-flagged LPG carriers to sail through the Strait of

Hormuz. Quoting sources, it identified the vessels as Shivalik and Nanda Devi.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

As BRICS chair, condemn attacks on Iran: Tehran's message to New Delhi

Along with Iran, grouping also has the UAE, Saudi Arabia as members

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, March 13

TEHRAN IS learnt to have reached out to Delhi to take the lead in issuing a statement on behalf of the BRICS, currently chaired by India, condemning the US and Israeli strikes against

Iran in the last two weeks.

This has put Delhi in a diplomatic pickle since it has stayed away from taking sides in the ongoing conflict.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has spoken to leaders of the countries in the region

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

DHARMA SWATANTRYA BILL, 2026

Maharashtra Bill on 'unlawful' conversion: Mother's first religion for child out of wedlock

Vallabh Ozarkar & Omkar Gokhale
Mumbai, March 13

IN A provision that appears to go beyond anti-conversion laws enacted in several states, the Dharma Swatantrya Bill, 2026, tabled in the Maharashtra Assembly on Friday, states that a child born from a marriage arising out of an "unlawful" religious conversion will be considered to belong to the religion followed by the mother before such a marriage/relationship.



Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnis at Vidhan Bhavan in Mumbai, Friday. AKASH PATIL

While some states like Haryana recognise inheritance

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Seeking ouster of 'partisan' CEC, Opposition submits notices in both Houses

120 MPs in LS, 73 in RS sign notice

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, March 13

CITING CHARGES including "partisan and discriminatory conduct" and "obstruction of investigation into electoral fraud and SIR" (Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls), the Opposition on Friday submitted notices in both Houses of Parliament for an impeachment motion against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar.

A senior TMC MP told *The Indian Express* that 120 Lok Sabha members and 73 Rajya Sabha members had signed the notices. "A total of 17 Opposition parties have supported the notice. It has been submitted in both Houses," the MP said.

As per procedure, the notice has to be signed by at least 100 members if moved in the Lok

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Happening today

● **PM NARENDRA** Modi will address a rally at the Brigade Parade Ground in Kolkata and inaugurate various projects.

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EXPRESS interview



WILL WIND UP ARMED OPS IF OUR PARTY IS LEGALISED, SAYS SURRENDERED MAOIST DEVUJI
REPORT, PAGE 6

Delhi SIR preparations crawl, CEO tells depts to let BLOs focus on task

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, March 13

FLAGGING THE slow progress of preparatory work for the revision of electoral rolls in Delhi, the Office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), Delhi, has asked government departments to ensure that teachers and other officials deployed as Booth Level Officers (BLOs) are not assigned additional duties

after office hours, so they can carry out the necessary field-work relating to the revision.

The letter has noted that the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the capital is expected to begin next month, that the preparatory exercise has progressed slowly — with only about 30 per cent of the required "mapping" exercise having been completed so far.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



BOOK LPG ONLY IF NEEDED: GOVT
PAGE 6

Oil price rise: Market sinks 5% in a week, logs worst 4-yr weekly fall

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, March 13

THE DOMESTIC stock market fell more than five per cent this week, marking its steepest weekly decline in nearly four years, driven by surging crude oil prices linked to the ongoing conflict in West Asia that has kept investors on edge. Since the crisis began late last month, companies listed on the BSE have collectively lost about Rs 34 lakh crore in investor

ECONOMY PAGE 13

WHY FPIs ARE DUMPING INDIAN STOCKS, PUSHING RUPEE DOWN

wealth even as the benchmark stock indices have dropped roughly eight per cent.

On Friday, the Sensex index ended 1.9 per cent, or 1,470.50

points, lower at 74,563.92 points as foreign investors went on a selling spree. The Nifty 50 closed 2.1 per cent lower at 23,151.10 points.

Both the indices are currently trading around their lowest levels in around a year. Despite reaching record highs on a couple of occasions, both have been in a consolidation phase over the past 18-24 months. They are now near February 2024 levels.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

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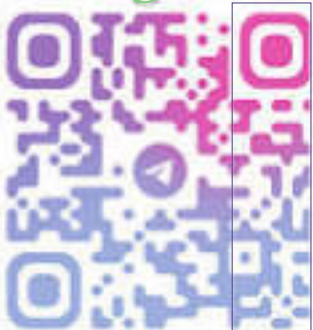
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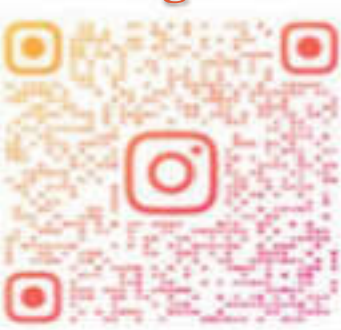
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WAR IN WEST ASIA

Amid oil supply crunch, the big winner – Russia



SUKALP SHARMA

THIS WAR has no winners, except maybe one that is not even fighting in it.

As Iran effectively chokes off the Strait of Hormuz in its escalating response to the US and Israel's attacks, Russia is making a wind-fall on the back of the reduced supply of crude oil as well as its spiralling prices. According to a *Financial Times* report, Moscow is estimated to have earned around \$150 million a day in extra oil revenue since the effective closure of the narrow transit passage for a fifth of the world's energy supplies.

Till a few days back, millions of barrels of Russian crude were languishing on the high seas with few willing buyers, thanks to US efforts to starve Moscow of oil revenues that could fund the Ukraine war. Now, America's own war against Iran has taken precedence. After issuing a 30-day "waiver" to Indian refiners last week for buying Russian crude that is already sitting in tankers on water, the US has now extended it to other countries too.

"To increase the global reach of existing supply, @USTreasury is providing a temporary authorization to permit countries to purchase Russian oil currently stranded at sea. This narrowly tailored, short-term measure applies only to oil already in transit and will not provide significant financial benefit to the Russian government, which derives the majority of its energy revenue from taxes assessed at the point of extraction," US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent posted on social media platform X.

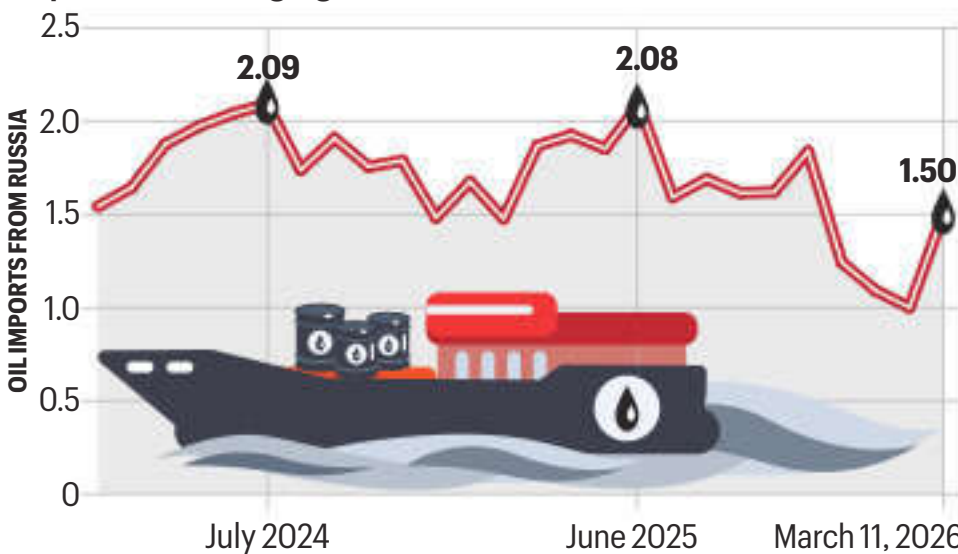
How does Russian oil waiver work?

The easing of sanctions, which will be in place for a month, means that the US will have no problem if countries import Russian crude that was loaded on or before 12:01 am eastern daylight time, or 9:31 am India time, on March 12.

While this move could help other countries secure some oil supplies, it is likely to help New Delhi as well as the India-specific waiver was for oil loaded on tankers before March 5.

Uneven flow

In recent months, India significantly cut down oil imports from Russia, its largest supplier. Now, amid the US waiver, imports are rising again. (FIGURES IN MILLION BARRELS PER DAY)



According to industry watchers, the US could be forced to ease sanctions further on Russian crude if the disruption to the global oil supplies via the Strait of Hormuz persists for an extended period.

Experts see these moves from Washington as part of Donald Trump's effort to prevent a further and sustained spike in international oil prices — and the consequent rise in domestic fuel prices in the US — given the midterm elections later this year.

"So far, there is only one winner in this war — Russia. It steadily undermines Ukraine's position by flouting international law. It gains new resources to finance its war against Ukraine as energy prices rise," European Council President António Costa said earlier this week at the European Union Ambassadors Conference in Brussels.

And while Bessent said in his X post on Friday that the temporary easing of sanctions on Russian oil on water will not provide significant financial benefit to Moscow, he said earlier that the financial gains Russia would accrue would be "unfortunate".

How has Russia benefited?

The West Asia war has led to a spurt in crude oil prices, which remain extremely volatile. At noon on Friday, benchmark Brent crude was around \$100 per barrel, almost 37% higher than nearly \$73 per barrel just before the US and Israel launched military strikes on Iran on February 28. So, like any other oil producer who is able to sell crude in this market, Russia gains from



An oil tanker hit by an Iranian strike at Khor al-Zubair port in Iraq, Wednesday. AP

higher oil prices. But that's not all. The price of Russian crude grades — mainly its flagship Urals — have appreciated more given the availability in an otherwise tight market and buyer interest.

Russian oil used to trade at a discount to crude benchmarks. The discounts have now largely disappeared, and there are reports of Russian oil even selling at a premium in some cases. Add to that the fact that the easing of sanctions by the US has made large volumes of Russian crude kosher for international buyers.

Around 130 million barrels of Russian crude was estimated to be on ships on water as of early March. Some of those volumes would have already been gobbled up by India and China, the biggest buyers of seaborne Russian crude. Additional volumes are likely to have come on water over the past couple of weeks as well.

"From a market perspective, Russian crude currently acts as one of the best supply hedges for Asian refiners. With persistent risks around the Strait of Hormuz and Middle East supply routes, refiners in Asia are naturally looking for barrels that are more secure and priced competitively, and Russian crude fits that role," said Sumit Ritolia, Lead Research Analyst, Refining & Modeling at Kpler, a commodity market analytics firm.

All this means Russia could rake in billions of dollars more as the war continues. And the longer the West Asian oil flows remain constricted, the more it benefits Russia.

Millions of barrels of Russian crude were languishing on the high seas. It is now in high demand as the war chokes energy flows & price spirals

asia, which has been facing a slowing economy and expanding budget deficit owing to its Ukraine war expenditure.

How is India affected?

With the conflict — now into its second week — suspending traffic through the Strait of Hormuz, India's Russian oil imports have shot up. In the first 11 days of the month, India imported 1.5 million barrels per day (bpd) of Russian oil, up around 50% from February levels, as per ship tracking data from Kpler. These volumes could increase if regular West Asian oil volumes through the strait are not resumed soon. Around 2.5-2.7 million bpd of India's crude imports — accounting for around half of the country's total oil imports — have crossed the strait in recent months; the longer-term average is around 40%. This oil is mainly from Iraq, Saudi Arabia, the UAE and Kuwait.

India had, in recent months, significantly cut down its oil imports from Russia, its largest oil supplier, amid trade negotiations with the US, as Washington made it a prerequisite for scrapping its 25% additional penal tariff (*see chart*).

In February, India had imported just over one million bpd of Russian crude, almost half of the 2025 peak of over 2 million bpd. Loadings of Russian crude for Indian ports, which averaged 1.7 million bpd last year, was just 0.7 million bpd in February. India is the world's third-largest consumer of crude oil and depends on imports to meet over 88% of its oil requirement.

But now the US is counting on India to buy more Russian oil. On Wednesday, Ambassador Sergio Gor said: "India has been a great partner in maintaining stable oil prices around the world. The United States recognizes ongoing purchases of Russian oil are a part of this effort. India is one of the largest consumers and refiners of oil and it is essential for the United States and India to work hand in hand for market stability for Americans and Indians."

A senior government official had said last week that India never stopped buying Russian crude, and the "waiver" appeared to be more for Washington's own legal and procedural requirements.

"What the waiver does is reduce some of the uncertainty around the trade and could potentially open the door for other Asian buyers who had stayed away (from Russian oil) since 2022," said Ritolia.

To compute the true costs of Iran conflict, look at the past



GRAPHS, DATA, PERSPECTIVES BY UDIT MISRA

WEEKLY ECONOMIC AND POLICY INSIGHTS USING DATA

SINCE THE US and Israel attacked Iran on February 28, initial estimates suggest a heavy running cost for this war. Last week, Israel's Finance Ministry claimed that the country is spending \$3 billion per week as it attacked Iran and defended itself from Iranian missiles. In the US, the costs are reportedly even higher. On Wednesday, the Department of Defense (or War, as the Trump administration calls it) told the US Congress in a briefing that the government had spent \$11.3 billion in the first six days of the war: close to \$2 billion a day.

For perspective, \$1 billion is roughly equal to Rs 9,000 crore. So, the US and Israel spent over Rs 1.3 lakh crore in six days.

Another way to look at this is to compare it with India's defence budget for FY 2026-27: Rs 7.8 lakh crore. At the going rate, in just six weeks — one of the many timelines US President Donald Trump has given since the war began — the two countries

would have spent as much as India's defence spending in the coming year.

Of course, it is possible that as the days and weeks go by, the direct running cost may come down. After all, Trump has said that almost all the targets that could be hit aerielly have been hit. But it is unclear how long this war will drag on, especially since there is no clarity on the exact goal.

Lessons from history

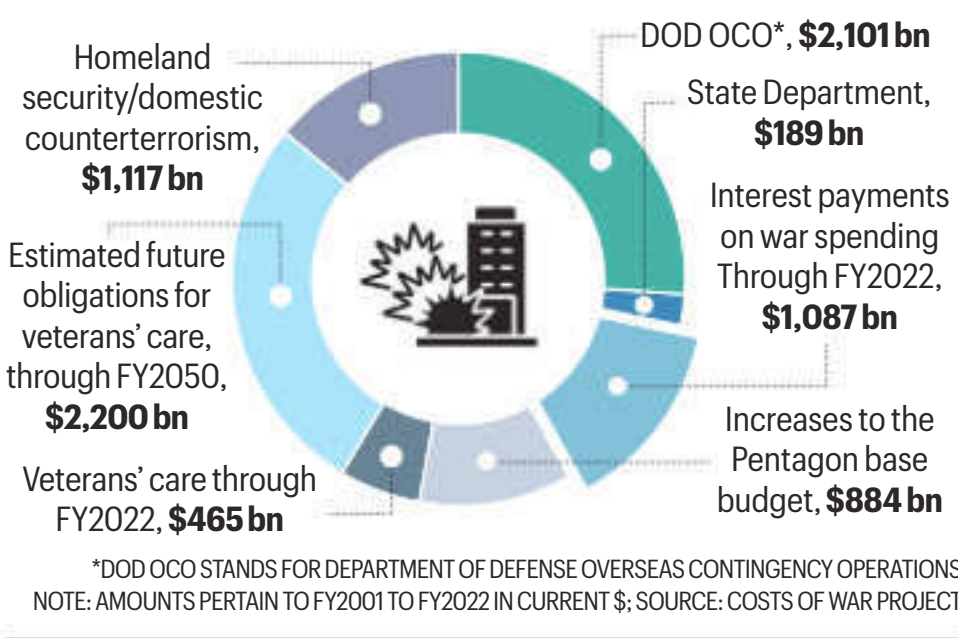
While accurately assessing the true cost of war is near impossible, one way to get a sense of the scale is to look at the cost of past wars. A 2021 study by Brown University's Costs of War project put the total budgetary costs and future obligations of the post-9/11 wars (including estimated future costs for veterans' care) at about \$8 trillion (*see chart*).

But even these costs are only those that will fall on the US government and American taxpayers. If this war settles down to a lower frequency of attacks and counterattacks, the focus of costs will shift from direct military costs to the US and Israel to indirect costs to the wider world, such as the cost of higher fuel prices.

Crude oil prices have shot up by almost 50% since the war began. That increase will now feed inflation globally, worsening the so-called cost of living crisis that started in

\$8-trillion burden

A snapshot of America's war-related spending after the 9/11 terror attack, and its obligations



*DOD OCO STANDS FOR DEPARTMENT OF DEFENSE OVERSEAS CONTINGENCY OPERATIONS NOTE: AMOUNTS PERTAIN TO FY2001 TO FY2022 IN CURRENT \$; SOURCE: COSTS OF WAR PROJECT

the wake of the Russia-Ukraine war.

But even such inflationary bumps fail to truly capture the real cost of war. For instance, what is the opportunity cost of any such war? Opportunity cost refers to the "money which could have gone towards societally beneficial expenditures such as infrastructure improvements, educational investments, and environmental protec-

tion" instead of military spending.

The non-economic costs

Beyond the economic costs, are the human costs — again, far more difficult to assess. The project found that around 940,000 people were killed by direct post-9/11 war violence in Iraq, Afghanistan, Syria, Yemen, and Pakistan between 2001 and 2023. Of these, over 432,000 were civilians.

The post-9/11 wars have also led to a severe undermining of civil liberties and human rights. "Domestically, the post-9/11 wars dramatically expanded mass surveillance, eroding constitutional protections, and intensified police militarization. Marginalized and racialized groups, from Muslims and Arabs to Black and Indigenous organizers to migrants, have borne the brunt of these consequences," the project noted.

Last, there are environmental costs because "military jets and vehicles consume petroleum-based fuels at an extremely high rate, and the vehicles used in the war zones produce tons of carbon monoxide, nitrogen oxides, hydrocarbons, and sulfur dioxide in addition to CO2". One of the key findings has been that the US Department of Defense is the world's single largest institutional consumer of oil — making it one of the world's top greenhouse gas emitters.

• LEGAL

OBC creamy layer: Why SC ruled against 'hostile'

Shyamlal Yadav
New Delhi, March 13

THE SUPREME Court on Wednesday ruled that income cannot be the sole criterion to decide the "creamy layer" among Other Backward Classes (OBCs), and settled the long-pending question of equivalence between public sector undertakings (PSUs) and private sector employees and those in the government sector. Those included in the creamy layer are not entitled to OBC reservation benefits.

What the top court said

The Division Bench of Justices PS Narasimha and R Mahadevan held: "The object of excluding the creamy layer is... not to create artificial distinctions between equally placed members of the same social class.... unequal treatment of similarly placed OBC candidates would not only be legally erroneous but constitutionally impermissible."

The Bench was hearing petitions arising due to an October 14, 2004, letter issued by the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) with regard to the creamy layer criterion, clarifying an Official Memorandum (OM) issued on September 8, 1993. The OM noted who is classified as OBC and who belongs to the creamy layer among them.

Creamy layer in OBC quota

The concept of creamy layer within the OBCs was introduced following the landmark 1992 SC ruling in *Indra Sawhney v. Union of India*, also known as the Mandal verdict.

For those in government jobs, the creamy layer specifies groups such as persons occupying constitutional posts; Group-A/Class-I officers of All India Services, Central services and state services; Group-B/Class-II services of Centre and state; employees of PSUs; officers of Armed Forces; professionals and those from trade and industry; property owners; and an income/wealth test. In a nutshell, if either parent is a direct recruit of Group-A, or is promoted before the age of 40, their children cannot take advantage of the OBC quota. Similarly, if both parents are Group-B direct recruits, their children will be covered under the creamy layer. The criterion for those not in the government sector was set at Rs 1 lakh per annum in 1993. It was revised in due course and since 2017, this income limit is Rs 8 lakh.

DoPT's clarification

Para 9 of DoPT's October 2004 clarification said that "the creamy layer status of sons and daughters of persons employed in organisations where equivalence or comparability of posts vis-à-vis posts in Government has not been evaluated is determined as follows: Income of the parents from the salaries and from the other sources (other than salaries and agriculture land) is determined separately. If either the income of the parents from the salaries or the income of the parents from other sources (other than salaries and agricultural land) exceeds the limit of Rs 2.5 lakh per annum [as it was then] for a period of three consecutive years, the sons and daughters of such persons shall be treated to fall in creamy layer."

The court noted that while the OM had excluded income from salary and agricultural income from the income/wealth test for determination of creamy layer status, the October 2004 letter directed inclusion of salary income of PSU and private sector employees. This resulted in hostile discrimination between wards of government servants and those of PSU and private sector employees, "thereby attracting the rigour of the equality doctrine under Articles 14, 15 and 16." **FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM/EXPLAINED**

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WAR IN WEST ASIA

Strait of Hormuz crisis spotlights a growing risk for Indian seafarers: Abandonment



SUNANDA MEHTA

THE WAR in West Asia, in which a number of tankers and merchant vessels near the Persian Gulf have come under attack, is throwing light on the risks faced by commercial sailors, especially Indians.

At least three Indian seafarers have been killed so far in Iranian attacks.

As ships continue to find themselves stranded near the Strait of Hormuz, industry stakeholders are warning of the increasing risk of "abandonments" — when shipowners cease all support to their crew and vessels.

Indians, who make up about 15% of the world's seafarer workforce — the second biggest share by nationality — top the list of "abandoned seafarers".

A recent report by the International Transport Workers' Federation (ITF),

which represents seafarers globally, put the number of abandoned Indian seafarers in 2025 at a record 1,125, representing nearly 18% of all global abandonment cases. The total number of ships abandoned was also a record — 410 in 2025 from 20 in 2016.

Around 740,000 seafarers are registered with India's Directorate General of Shipping (DGS) and 3,23,479 of them are active seafarers. Here's a look at why abandonment happens and why Indians are the worst affected.

What is 'seafarer abandonment'?

Seafarer abandonment refers to a scenario where shipowners cut off all support to their crew, leaving them stranded without pay, food, shelter, medical care or a way home, either aboard a vessel or in a foreign port. For many seafarers, especially those from low-income backgrounds, disembarking abandoned vessels without a salary is impossible — they often would have already shelled out hefty sums of money to agents for jobs or training certifications. Additionally, port or visa restrictions may prevent them from going ashore.

Why would owners abandon their crew and vessels?

When faced with situations such as high operational costs, debt, or even war and strife, ship owners may opt to cut ties altogether rather than pay wages, cover repatriation or maintain ageing vessels.

But enabling these abandonments is the "flag of convenience" (FOC) system. Each commercial vessel needs to register with a country's flag so that it has a legal nationality. This determines the laws a vessel must follow and the protections its crew receives.

But since international rules allow flagging anywhere, ship owners pick countries (called Flag States) that allow them to bypass safety standards, avoid taxes, and skirt laws protecting labour conditions and wages. The FOC system also conceals the ownership, enabling fly-by-night operators. It is little surprise, then, that FOC vessels dominate abandonment. The ITF estimates that 30% of the 1,00,000-strong global merchant fleet flies FOCs, and 90% of the abandoned ships in 2024 were under FOCs.

Chirag Bahri, operations manager at the International Seafarers Welfare and Assis-

tance Network (ISWAN), said the turmoil in West Asia threatens more abandonments. "If this crisis persists, shipping companies in the Gulf region may encounter significant financial difficulties, which could threaten their survival, potentially resulting in more seafarers being left stranded on their vessels," says Bahri.

What are the recent incidents in which Indian seafarers have found themselves abandoned?

In March 2026, 20 Indians and two others were stranded on the *MV Manali* near Iran's Bandar Abbas Port amid bombings.

In 2025, 19 people, 17 of them Indians, were stranded off UAE on the tanker *Global Peace*. Since June last year, the crew of the *Eleen Armonia*, including four Indians, has allegedly been abandoned off the coast of Nigeria — with no pay and battling severe mental strain in isolation.

In 2024, crew members on the *MV Captain Tarek*, one of them an Indian, were left abandoned for several months off Yemen.

In July 2025, the crew members of the *MT Nathan* found themselves abandoned

in a war zone for months in a port in South Ukraine, caught between Russian bombing and the Ukrainian air defence.

The West Asian and Persian Gulf regions, conflict-ridden waters, dominated recent incidents of abandonment. Over 100 Indians were repatriated from 14 vessels in places like Sharjah (UAE), Tartus (Syria), Shinas (Oman) and Qatar in 2025-2026.

Why are Indian seafarers susceptible to abandonment?

Indian seafarers top abandonment lists owing to a mix of socioeconomic pressures, systemic flaws in recruitment, and a surge in fraudulent practices, says Bahri.

"India's vast population, particularly in tier-3 and tier-4 cities, sees seafaring as a golden escape from poverty — salaries here can dwarf local earnings by multiples. But unlike earlier generations with family shipping ties, many rural newcomers fall into traps set by rogue agents. These agents charge high fees for phantom jobs, peddle fake or bought foreign certificates, and dangle promises of instant wealth," he says. Bahri also points to policy gaps. "The

What protections do seafarers have?

Stranded seafarers need to swiftly alert ITF inspectors worldwide for aid, wage negotiation and repatriation. Indian seafarers can also dial the DGS's round-the-clock helpline. In India, the DGS is responsible for verifying the credentials of ships, owners and recruitment and placement agencies. But the shipping community alleges that lax regulatory oversight is behind issues such as abandonment.

Capt PC Meena, Deputy Director General of Shipping (Crew) at the DGS, said the regulator has tightened compliance requirements for recruitment and placement service licensees and shipping firms. He said 86 vessels were blacklisted for repeated abuses against Indians in September 2025 alone.

The writer is Resident Editor, Pune

● **WEB EXCLUSIVE**
 ‘The war on Iran might just strengthen its resolve to get nuclear weapons.’ —
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Tariffs to LPG, a shape-shifting crisis

THE 1997 Asian Contagion, triggered by the collapse of the Thai baht before spreading to other countries in the region and beyond, was a financial crisis. So was the American subprime mortgage crisis leading to the global Great Recession from late 2007 to mid-2009. India’s twin-deficit and twin-balance-sheet problems of the last decade were also primarily “financial” crises. Financial imbalances — from currency devaluations and capital flight, the bursting of housing and asset bubbles or high fiscal and external current account deficits — spilled over into the real economy, causing growth and investment slowdowns. The “real” impact of over-leveraged private corporates not investing and bad loans-saddled banks not lending on the Indian economy was felt through much of the 2010s.

The present decade, in contrast, has seen more “real” crises. Covid pandemic, Russia’s invasion of Ukraine and the on-going US-Israel-versus-Iran conflict have all originated from the physical, as opposed to the financial, world. These have profoundly disrupted physical human interaction or movement of goods. Just as the virus made people afraid of meeting one another, the wars have created anxiety among exporters and importers, and producers and consumers alike. The movement of vessels through the Strait of Hormuz, which handles about a fifth of the world’s total petroleum liquid consumption and liquefied natural gas trade, has stopped due to non-availability of war risk insurance for hull and cargo. The very reports of attacks on ships and their sailors being stranded at sea are enough to freeze international trade. The ripple effects on other real economic activities don’t take long in coming.

Like with Covid and the Russia-Ukraine war, which sent global oil and food prices skyrocketing, the current West Asia conflict will have a spillover from the “real” to the “financial”. For India, it could entail a further weakening of the rupee and renewed pressures on both the balance of payments and government finances. This, just when the Centre as well as states have been working on fiscal consolidation and reduction of debt-GDP ratios that had spiked to all-time-highs in 2020-21, because of pandemic-time spending and economic contraction. Financial crises resulting from debt-fuelled growth, over-investment and speculative bubbles are normal — even considered part of the business cycle — in most market economies. The “real” crises of the kind seen in this decade, including those emanating from Donald Trump’s tariff wars, have more to do with geopolitics. It makes economic policymaking much more complicated.

On climate change, mind the science-policy gap

IN 2023, scientists began debating the need to quantify the extent of global warming. Natural fluctuations, such as El Niño, made it difficult to ascertain if the faster rise in temperatures was due to climate change. Now, an analysis by Stefan Rahmstorf of the University of Potsdam, Germany, and US statistician Grant Foster has confirmed the links between the two. The researchers isolated the influence of phenomena such as El Niño, volcanic eruptions and solar irradiance to affirm that the pace of global warming has doubled since 2014, compared to the decade before it. Their study, published in *Geophysical Research Letters* a few days ago, reckons that the Paris Pact’s target of keeping temperature rise to below 1.5 degrees Celsius below pre-industrial levels could be out of reach by 2030. The study comes in the wake of a *Nature* paper that concludes that sea-level rise — caused by global heating — could be far higher than previously understood, including in IPCC reports. The two studies confirm the fears of scientists — the climate system is already in uncharted territory. As another analysis, published on Tuesday in the journal *Environmental Research: Health*, points out, a third of the world’s population now lives in areas — including large parts of India — where heat severely limits human activity.

It took careful diplomacy to include the 1.5-degree target in the Paris Pact. Since then, diplomacy has not kept pace with science. Take the net-zero target. Two different methodologies are used to calculate this goal — one deployed by IPCC scientists and a much looser method adopted by national policymakers. The latter, criticised for not reckoning with the fact that multiple entities can claim the same emission cuts, has found its way into climate negotiations. Scientists who framed the net-zero concept warn that reliance on this method will artificially inflate progress.

Every fraction of a degree of warming will make adaptation more expensive. As the *Environmental Research: Health* study warns, extreme heat will affect not only the elderly but also the young and healthy. Public health experts, agriculture scientists and energy specialists have blueprints to increase resilience. It’s up to policymakers to make optimum use of their inputs.

In Radić’s architecture, poetics of space

WORDS OFTEN fail critics trying to describe the work of Chilean architect Smiljan Radić, recipient of the 2026 Pritzker Architecture Prize, architecture’s most coveted award. His futuristic modernism is sometimes interpreted as “conceptually evasive”, and, at other times, as “Mies van der Rohe-meets-*Star Trek*”. Spanning cultural and commercial buildings, residences, and pavilions, each project is marked by a unique dialogue between structure, material and context. Ranging from minimalist, sharply geometric forms to sculptural, almost fantastical constructions, they challenge conventional notions of space.

Radić’s buildings allow the city in. In the Biobío Theatre, he and his collaborators used woven fiberglass over 8,000 sqm, throwing the building’s skeleton open to the city in its translucence. The VIK Winery in Millahue is mostly underground, with the remaining structure peeping out lightly above ground. For Alexander McQueen’s Spring/Summer 2022 show in London, he created a stage almost like a soap bubble, against the city’s skyline. Radić’s architecture celebrates the weathering of materials, the “pretty ugliness” of objects, and the fragility of time and nature.

Once considered the end of the world, post-Pinochet Chile has become a site where architects explore material versatility and technical finesse. Radić’s work, often inspired by literary or artistic references, succeeds not only because it honours legacy but because it offers inventive paths to the future. Blending experimentation with a deep sensitivity to context, it offers lessons for other architects, showing how architecture can be both rooted in place and radically inventive.

LPG cylinder crunch hits home, singses stories of welfare and aspiration

SINCE THEIR introduction in 1955, two implements of Indian domestic life have remained steadfastly rooted in the national imagination as symbols of well-being as well as intergenerational class mobility. One is the pressure cooker and the other is the LPG cylinder. Their non-Indian origins notwithstanding, they have iconic status as objects that both represent modernity and give rise to bonds of family. In popular culture, the idea of the modern Indian family is indispensably built around the idea of a kitchen equipped with one or more pressure cookers and (and even more desirably) multiple LPG cylinders. The plump red cylinder with faded company logo is the object of both domestic aspirations and welfare. It is not for nothing that old films wanting to show domestic poverty would do it through a scene of a woman blowing into a smoke-spewing *chulha*, tears streaming down her face.

The political importance of the LPG cylinder — or, rather, the fuel that gives it meaning — was recognised in the 2016 Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana (PMUY), intended to provide clean cooking fuel to rural and poor households. The BJP’s publicity strategy centred around billboards that showed women in poses of happiness and gratitude as they receive cylinders from the Prime Minister. But the route to the well-being of the Indian kitchen and family is entangled in the global geopolitics of the US-

Israeli war with Iran and the subsequent blocking of the Strait of Hormuz by the latter. The majority of LPG supplies are made up of imports and around 90 per cent of these pass through the Strait of Hormuz. While global media outlets give considerable airtime to energy experts who fret over the effect of petrol price increases in the US and Europe and the growing consumer anger, there is far less coverage of the effects of the war on some of the world’s most vulnerable populations.

Multiple studies indicate that while the burning of solid fuel — wood, for example — adds to the overall air pollution, its health effects are most severe on the poor. There are four intertwined aspects to this: Class, caste, gender, and the rural-urban divide. At the most general level, biomass fuels affect the poor much more than the better-off both due to the density of the population where the poor are forced to live and the constricted nature of their residential dwellings. Individual households with a high level of biomass use suffer disproportionately whereas those who live in the locality but have a lower instance of using such fuel also suffer due to exposure to the outdoor air pollution in their locality.

Government data show that access to clean fuels such as LPG is crucially dependent on caste. In both urban and rural areas, for



SANJAY SRIVASTAVA

With women’s access to LPG, studies suggest that the time that is saved allows for leisure activities. Women are able to utilise it for activities that generate income. This secures a measure of personal autonomy

Amid the gloom, an opportunity to rebuild



K P NAYAR

WARS BRING windfalls. The ongoing conflict in West Asia is no exception. India can gain, too, but the public discourse in this country has so far dwelt entirely on doomsday scenarios — high oil prices, evacuation imperatives, job losses in overseas labour markets and the like. I have been a witness to fortunes made in the Persian Gulf from every outbreak of turmoil since the triumphant return of Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini to Tehran from exile in 1979. Smart countries in the lower parts of this region have thrived from every war — there have been many in its proximity — since Iran’s Islamic Revolution. All this runs against India’s traditional ethos and public policies. It needs to change because times have changed. If India does not change, it will lose, and the loss to altruism and compassion will be borne by this country’s 1.4 billion people.

I arrived in the Gulf, 11 months before Khomeini’s return, to start the first broadsheet English newspaper on the Arab side of the region. With me were six Indian journalists, a British editor and a Bangladeshi news editor, who had spent many years at Xinhua and was the only foreign journalist in Beijing during the aftershocks of the Cultural Revolution. Nineteen months after Khomeini took control of Iran, Saddam Hussein, Iraq’s then president, ordered an invasion of his eastern neighbour. The war lasted eight years, caused deaths estimated at half a million and ended in a draw brokered by the UN. Dubai thrived during this period by supplying Iran with everything it needed through the port of Bandar Abbas. This port is less than two nautical miles from the emirate and it takes only between 16 and 24 hours for cargo ships to reach it. It was like a lucky lottery ticket for Dubai’s merchants — many of whom are of Persian descent — that such vessels could avoid the most dangerous choke points in wartime in the Strait of Hormuz. As a reporter, I went every six months to the Dubai ports and customs department to check re-export figures, a barometer of the emirate’s prosperity in those days before Dubai grew into anything remotely like what it is now. Re-exports went up by leaps and bounds. Such windfalls were repeated during the war to free Kuwait from Iraqi occupation in 1991 and the US invasion that overthrew Saddam Hussein in 2003.

How can India gain from the dent in the

image of Gulf countries as safe havens from constant Arab upheavals without appearing to fish in troubled waters? Abu Dhabi and Dubai are leading MICE (Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and Exhibitions) locations. The Abu Dhabi National Exhibition Centre (ADNEC), the largest such venue in the Arab world, hosts more than 100 international events every year. Dubai’s Expo City does the same. Cancellations of some of these events are inevitable now because global MICE programmes require certainty. Instead of going in for cancellations, India can use its friendly relations with the UAE to shift some of these events to Delhi, Mumbai or Bengaluru, which have venues that match ADNEC and Expo City in capacity, amenities and comfort. Yashobhoomi in the national capital, the Bangalore International Exhibition Centre and Mumbai’s Jio World Centre are currently underutilised. MICE is a multi-billion-dollar business, but India has never had a strategy or credible plan to attract this business.

Persuading ADNEC and Expo City to shift some of their mammoth events this year to India — even if they have to be downsized — instead of cancelling them is a stopgap arrangement. But it can be built upon because of the opportunities such relocation will allow to expose India’s recently enhanced MICE infrastructure — like Bharat Mandapam in Delhi — to the global exhibition and conference industry. Fortuitously, this chance coincides with the appointment of an economic diplomat, Jawed Ashraf, as chairman of the Indian Trade Promotion Organisation (ITPO). As he works on a complete reorientation of ITPO’s global outreach, Ashraf has been keen to bring in the best practices of another MICE location, Singapore, where he was high commissioner. Disruptions in the Gulf offer him an opportunity, if only India is ready to be self-serving.

Dubai’s reputation was built over 40 years of hard and imaginative work. If the war in West Asia does not stop soon, it will take as many decades to rebuild confidence in the Gulf. India used a windfall from the war in Ukraine until Trump stepped in. But those were government-to-government windows and were existential for India. The opportunities popping up now are people-centric and can benefit everyone, from some entrepreneurs to corporate leaders.

The writer, a senior journalist, has worked in West Asia

The many limitations of a social-media ban



ANGELINA DASH

THE KARNATAKA and Andhra Pradesh governments have announced their intention to introduce measures to restrict social-media access for children below the ages of 16 and 13 years respectively. With law-making powers relating to internet and communications governance typically falling under the Union List, it is unclear whether states can, in fact, regulate children’s access to social media through legislation.

Fragmented approaches to social-media bans can present challenges in applicability, particularly in the case of non-uniform age thresholds across different states. It is also unclear how different states may intend to assign the onus with respect to enforceability. A broader social media ban for children is also contentious due to several constraints. It is challenging to identify an age threshold, as it could be onerous to ascertain the extent of agency and evolving capacity that an individual child may demonstrate. Moreover, online age verification raises several privacy concerns, since such regulation would require every user to verify their age to access platforms, through mechanisms which have not fully been specified. Such a ban also fails to account for challenges such as shared device usage. A ban may also further limit online expression for girls and LGBTQIA+ children.

As per India’s data protection law, which is yet to be enforced, even when children are past an identified age threshold, they will still need parental consent to access most platforms. Notwithstanding the prevailing law in their state, parents may choose to exercise caution in a manner that disregards their child’s individual capacity and agency. Social-media bans, coupled with existing parental consent requirements under data protection frameworks, may shift the narrative entirely towards restricting children’s access, whereas the real question relates to how we can safeguard children from the very real harms that present themselves online. With children continuing to be exposed to inherent platform design choices that can foster safety harms, the crux of the problem often remains unaddressed.

Rather than restricting access, policies and legal frameworks should empower children and parents to navigate these platforms safely. The Centre is reportedly looking to introduce a law that attempts to take a “nuanced and graded approach” to regulating access to social media for children. However, it is imperative that consultative processes take a multi-stakeholder approach, including consultation with civil society, academia, and children. Any law must acknowledge different harms, such as grooming, sexual content, addiction, and mental-health challenges, and explore targeted mitigation strategies as opposed to a sweeping ban. The law must also build pathways towards equipping children, parents and educators with tools for responsible social media use.

It is crucial that legislation consider factors such as India’s linguistic diversity, which may not only impact how platforms detect children’s accounts but can also dictate the accuracy with which safety measures used by platforms work. Additionally, a narrow focus on social-media platforms alone ignores risks that may present themselves on alternative mediums such as gaming platforms and large language models. Policies and legal frameworks must, therefore, safeguard the best interests of children in a manner that accounts for emerging technologies and India’s unique considerations and challenges.

The writer is project officer at Centre for Communication Governance, National Law University Delhi

40 YEARS AGO

March 14, 1986



Chavan finalises ministers

SB CHAVAN, Maharashtra Chief Minister-elect, met the Prime Minister, Rajiv Gandhi, in New Delhi. Chavan is expected to return to Bombay soon. He said the list of the members of his Cabinet was finalised after his meeting with Rajiv Gandhi, which lasted about 90 minutes. After arriving here from Bombay, Chavan drove straight to the Prime Minister’s house. Prabha Rau, MPCC(I) president, who accompanied him from Bombay, waited at Chavan’s residence.

India told of killings

INDIA WAS told of a UN panel on the escalating violence and indiscriminate killings of

the minority Tamils in Sri Lanka and expressed the hope that President Jayewardene would resist political pressures and work out a peaceful solution to the ethnic problem in his country. Speaking in the committee on the elimination of racial discrimination, Shanti Sadiq Ali said the situation in Sri Lanka had “deteriorated considerably” with the conditions of the minority (Tamils) becoming “very precarious.”

PM’s TV ‘exposure’

A DOORDARSHAN discussion on the projection of the Prime Minister on television vs the official control of the media has run into rough weather, thanks to the government’s noncooperative attitude. The discussion

was to be telecast in *Newsline*, a fortnightly programme presented by a private agency under a Calcutta editor. The original idea was to interview L K Advani, information minister in the Janata government, Mani Shankar Aiyar, the Prime Minister’s publicity aide, and Amita Malik, a media critic.

Marcos papers

THE REAGAN administration has decided to turn over to the Philippines government copies of all the 1,500 financial documents brought to Hawaii by Ferdinand Marcos, amidst reports that President Corazon Aquino has frozen all assets and properties in the Philippines of the deposed president, his family and associates.

● WORDLY WISE

Markets can remain irrational longer than you can remain solvent.

— John Maynard Keynes



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Growth has been less strong than it seems. The misreading has complicated policy



ABHISHEK ANAND, JOSH FELMAN AND ARVIND SUBRAMANIAN

RECENTLY, THE government released a new series of GDP numbers. It did so for two main reasons. First, the weights of the various goods and services needed updating, a step that was long overdue as India's economy has gone through tremendous changes since the weights were last established in 2011-12. Second, shortcomings in the methodology for estimating GDP needed to be addressed.

The process of changing the methodology has been commendably consultative, for which the Ministry of Statistics and Policy Implementation (MoSPI) deserves credit. But assessing whether the shortcomings have been substantively addressed will take time. And it will ultimately depend on the quality and plausibility of the new numbers.

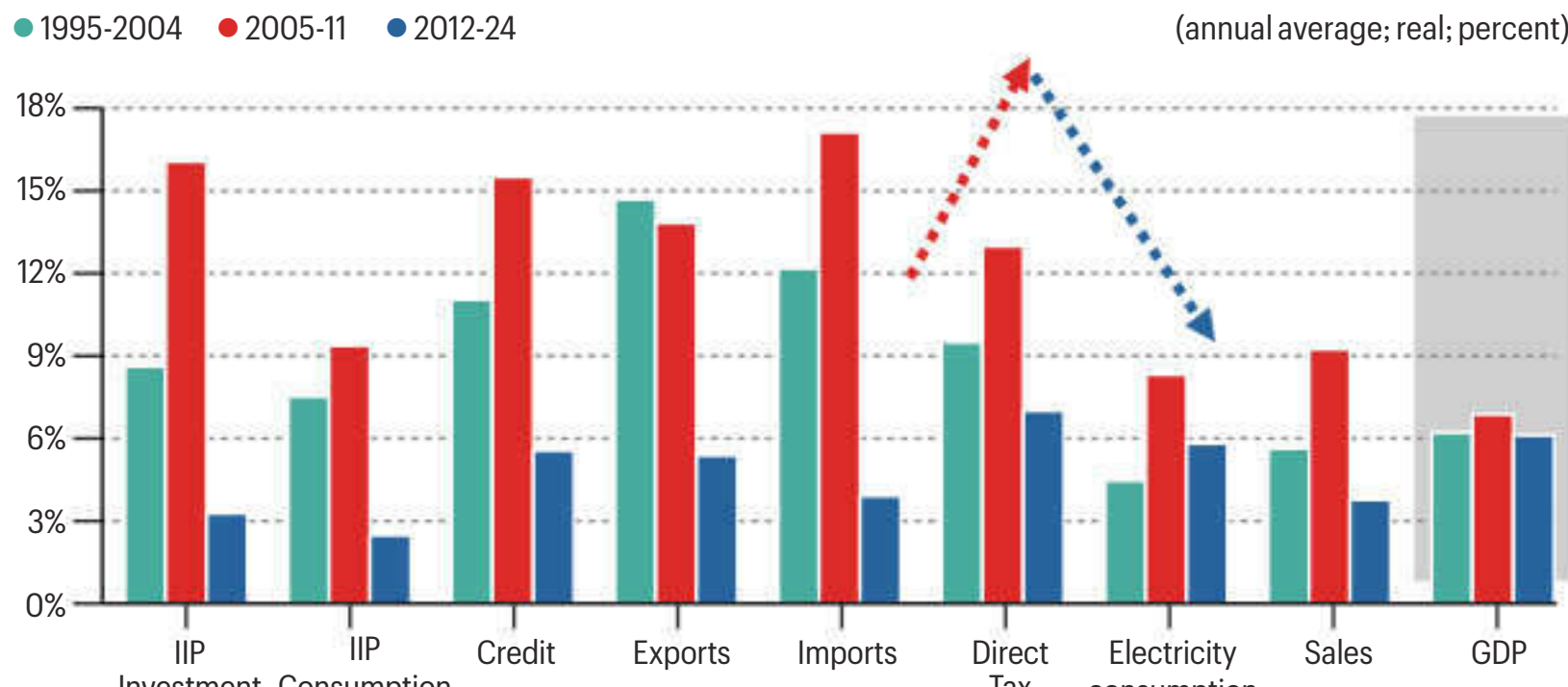
Prima facie, while there have clearly been improvements, some oddities remain. For example, goods inflation (as measured by the manufacturing GVA deflator) is strangely negative for 10 quarters, which has led to an unusual jump in the sector's real growth rate. Also, import deflators are radically different from those in the previous series, which has produced sharp changes in real import growth.

But before we can fully assess the new methodology, we need to understand: What were the problems with the old methodology? Were they serious? In a new paper, we try to answer these questions.

Start with the manifestation of the problem. Until a decade ago, there was a close relationship between the GDP numbers and the standard macro-indicators that economists monitor to gauge the health of the economy: Exports, credit, taxes, electricity consumption, sales and the index of industrial production. These relationships broke down, however, after the methodology was radically revised in January 2015.

A key problem was the use of inappropriate data sources, notably proxying the per-

• GROWTH RATES OF MACRO-INDICATORS OF GDP



ALL VARIABLES ARE IN REAL TERMS; SEE PAPER FOR DETAILS. SOURCES: RBI, CEA, MOSPI

formance of the informal sector by using data from the formal sector. This may have been a reasonable approach in normal times. But after 2015, the informal sector was hit disproportionately by three severe shocks: Demonetisation, the introduction of the GST and Covid. As a result, the methodology overstated informal sector performance — a serious problem, since informal enterprises accounted for over 45 per cent of the economy in 2011-12.

The other major problem was the use of inappropriate deflators. Much attention has been paid to the lack of "double deflation". The bigger issue was the use of inappropriate price indices, most notably the use of the wholesale price index (WPI), to deflate services production even though the WPI doesn't really capture service prices. This was a particularly acute problem over the past decade when the WPI plunged, driven largely by the collapse in the price of oil. As a result, inflation was understated and real growth was overstated. These problems mattered enormously, causing significant misestimation when the 2015 methodology was applied to GDP growth numbers, initially from 2011-12 onwards and then retrospectively to figures going back to 2004-05.

Growth was overstated by about 1½-2 percentage points on

Much attention has been paid to the lack of 'double deflation'. The bigger issue was the use of inappropriate price indices, most notably the WPI, to deflate services production even though the WPI doesn't really capture service prices

average between 2011-12 and 2023-24, with inappropriate data and deflators contributing roughly equally. As a result, we estimate the economy grew at 4-4½ per cent on average instead of 6 per cent over these 12 years. Estimates of India's potential growth need to be re-calibrated accordingly.

For the earlier period, the 2015 methodology had the opposite effect: It underestimated growth by about 1-1½ percentage points on average between 2004-05 and 2011-12. The net result is a mischaracterisation of the 20-year trajectory of growth. The boom of the aughties and the subsequent slowdown have been erased from history, replaced by a picture of steady, rapid growth.

The figures show the problem. The macro-indicators surged from the 1990s to the early aughties but then decelerated sharply, falling even below pre-2005 levels (see arrows). Yet official GDP growth figures (the shaded area) portray a picture of stable growth over the entire period.

In this picture, there was no India Shining between 2003 and 2010, when the heady, dizzy dynamism was palpable everywhere, including in all the major macro-economic aggregates. Nor was there any slowdown after the global financial crisis, any impact of the twin balance sheet problem, or

of the four major post-2015 shocks: Demonetisation, GST, the ILFS-triggered credit meltdown and Covid. The official data suggest that the last two decades were an uninterrupted idyll of 6-7 per cent growth.

This misreading complicated macro-economic policy: At various periods the data signalled strength when the economy was weak, and in others, it suggested that policy should be eased when growth was strong. It also attenuated the urgency for reforms, especially in the period between 2014-15 and 2019-20. After all, why change the policy framework when it was already producing world-beating growth?

In recent years, there have been frequent invocations of puzzles. If growth is strong, why is private investment so weak? Why is net FDI declining? Why are capacity utilisation, wage growth, employment growth so tepid? More recently, why was there pressure on the rupee if real growth was so much greater than anywhere in the world? Each puzzle elicits its own complex and different explanation. But in the spirit of Occam's Razor, there is one simple, albeit partial, explanation for all of them: Growth has been less strong than it appears!

India has taken pride in being amongst the fastest-growing economies in the world. According to IMF data, India has been the fourth-fastest-growing major economy between 2011 and 2023. But even on our revised estimates, India will remain amongst the top seven or eight fastest-growing economies. National pride may yet be warranted but it does not require a statistical crutch.

Our analysis is both complimentary and complementary to the latest effort by MoSPI. Complimentary because MoSPI has now attempted to address the challenges identified by our analysis and other scholars. Complementary because while the new methodology will apply to future estimates, our research is about the past, focusing on correcting the historical record. Our research will also provide a benchmark for assessing the new methodology when MoSPI undertakes the backcasting exercise to come up with estimates for the last one or two decades. Hopefully, out of the fog of the past there will be light ahead.

The writers are affiliated respectively to Madras Institute for Development Studies, JH Consulting and Peterson Institute for International Economics. Data and replication code for the paper are available at the PIIE web-site

In Nepal and Bangladesh, the people have spoken



RAM RAJYA
BY RAM MADHAV

INDIA IS not only the world's largest democracy but a successful one, too. It is a model for its South Asian neighbours to emulate. The last couple of months saw two important neighbours, Bangladesh and Nepal, successfully demonstrating their democratic credentials. Bangladesh held its elections on February 12, while Nepal went to the polls on March 5. Two things stood out: One, the peaceful manner in which they were conducted, and two, the commendable maturity that the electors in both countries displayed.

Bangladesh and Nepal witnessed popular revolts that led to the ouster of their respective heads of government: Sheikh Hasina in August 2024 and K P Oli in September 2025. These revolts were not peaceful. The abruptness and scale of violence in both cases prompted some observers to suspect the involvement of foreign agencies. But there were genuine reasons for popular unrest in both countries.

Bangladesh remained under an unelected government led by Nobel laureate Muhammad Yunus for an unusually long period. The Yunus government's antics endeared it neither to its people nor to neighbours like India; India-Bangladesh relations touched a nadir. The National Citizen Party, backed by the student groups that spearheaded the agitation against Hasina, was seen as an important contender for power along with the fundamentalist Jamaat-e-Islami. In the run-up to the elections, many suspected that the two parties, with the backing of the interim government, would emerge as frontrunners.

But the voters in Bangladesh demonstrated utmost wisdom and maturity in offering a landslide majority to the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP), a seasoned warhorse in the country's politics. The BNP, under the leadership of Tarique Rahman, is best suited to provide a stable government with credibility and experience at this crucial juncture.

The BNP's priorities include implementation of the constitutional and political reforms approved by the citizens in a referendum conducted by the Yunus administration in February 2025. The reform proposals include, among others, limiting the prime minister to two consecutive terms and creating an independent anti-corruption body. While Yunus followed an overtly anti-India policy, Rahman is expected to bring balance and bonhomie back into the relationship.

In Nepal, the voters chose a new party that came into the electoral scene just a few years ago. The Rastriya Swatantra Party, led by 50-year-old journalist-turned-politician Rabi Lamichhane, and 35-year-old rapper and youth sensation (also former mayor of Kathmandu) Balendra Shah, registered an unprecedented victory by winning more than two-thirds of the seats. Nepal opted for younger faces and new leaders, decisively rejecting the Nepali Congress and the Communist Party of Nepal (UML), led by septuagenarians like Sher Bahadur Deuba and K P Sharma Oli.

Although Nepal began its democratic journey in 1990, it never succeeded in establishing stable governments. There were more than a dozen prime ministerial tenures during the constitutional monarchy between 1990 and 2008, and 14 since the abolition of the monarchy in 2008. The 2026 election is a watershed moment because a single-party majority government is being formed. It will provide greater stability and allow for mature decision-making.

No democracy can be perfect, and no election will be complaint-free. But India has always been more comfortable dealing with fellow democracies, except for Pakistan, where a sham democracy prevails with the country's military looming large. Earlier, the Maldives (in 2023) and Sri Lanka (in 2024) conducted elections peacefully. In Myanmar, elections were held in December 2025-January 2026. All these governments enjoy excellent relations with India. Given its historically strong people-to-people ties with neighbours, India should proactively reach out to the new governments in Bangladesh and Nepal and rebuild relations, which have suffered some setbacks in the last few years. After all, as Atal Bihari Vajpayee said, "We can change our friends but not neighbours."

The writer, president, India Foundation, is with the BJP



LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

SC vs NCERT

TO BE angry over the textbooks issue even after NCERT's deletion and apology appears excessive for the apex court ('In blacklisting experts, SC does itself disservice', IE, March 13). In a wider framework, it risks creating a chilling effect on teachers, authors, and publishers, who may hesitate to state even alleged details that could reflect adversely on an institution. It also raises concerns of a double standard, that is, when similar institutional protection is often demanded by minorities or religious bodies. Guarding faith in institutions is one thing, but measures that instill fear run contrary to our constitutional values.

Shaswat Jena, Indrapuram

THE MORAL authority of an institution is paramount and nothing must dent it ('In blacklisting experts, SC does itself disservice', IE, March 13). In the case of NCERT, the reaction of the SC is being seen as an overreach without a matching cause. It would have been better to show intent to own, correct, and move forward. We have high hopes from our strong setup of governance, including the legislature, executive and judiciary.

Sanjeev Raina, Noida

Move to impeach

THE OPPOSITION parties in India are in dire straits. They are hard-pressed by a series of defeats and the high-handedness of state institutions, both of which are mutually reinforcing. Their own conduct has exacerbated their predicament ('Question CEC, but move to impeach is unwise', IE, March 13). There is scarcely any issue on which it has fought the government tooth and nail. Rarely is an issue pursued with diligence. This shifting of goalposts has reduced the stature of the Opposition to a caricature. This explains why state institutions continue to treat them unfairly with impunity, while they simultaneously fail to rally meaningful public support.

Anirudh Parashar, Chandigarh



RAMIN JAHANBEGLOO

THE WAR between Iran and the US and Israel is in its second week. The conflict is increasingly turning into a test of will between the Iranian regime and a multifront military alliance. This is a moment of uncertainty for the Iranian nation — caught between intensifying attacks, geopolitical tensions, and internal repression. Iran's strategy is clear: Survive the war. Iran has expanded the confrontation with Israel and the US because this is the only strategy for the survival of the Islamic regime. The Iranian regime is weakened, but it is not decimated. Young Iranians are also pushing back against the religious policies and cultural repression of the current regime.

Hope is a necessary component for creating a better future for Iranians, but the war does not follow a written script. US President Donald Trump has no exit strategy; he seems to be offering the international community conflicting signals on how long the US war with Iran will last. Consequently, what started on February 28 as an attempt to end the Islamic regime and its hegemony in the region turned into the erosion of the political balance in the Persian-Arab Gulf. Both Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu know that the Iranian Regime cannot win this war, but what they

In Iran, the military mindset — in favour of the escalation of the war — is winning against the political strategy of a reduction in tensions with the West

Forces of martyrdom, military lead charge in Iran

seem to be underestimating is the potential of the Shia ideology of martyrdom. This is embedded in the institution of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) and its actions, and is used to justify regional expansion, hostility toward the US, and the eradication of the state of Israel. It is by favouring this view that the Iranian regime survived the eight-year war with Saddam Hussein. This worldview cannot be destroyed by bombs; it is faith-based.

For four decades, the ayatollahs and the IRGC amplified the role of the Iranian regime as a hegemonic power in West Asia and the Levant. But today, with the degradation of Hezbollah in Lebanon and the collapse of the Bashar al-Assad regime in Syria, Iran's hegemonic potential has been fatally compromised. Iran still has the capacity to turn this war into a "religious war" by mobilising the Shia communities across Asia. We saw an example of this during the pro-Iran protest at the US consulate in Karachi. Many still remember the suicidal missions of young Iranian volunteers during the Iran-Iraq War (1980-1988).

Today, the scenes of jubilation that followed the death of the Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, in cities like Tehran and Shiraz are now far away. The

election of Mojtaba Khamenei as the new Iranian Supreme Leader is a clear sign that the headline factions in the establishment will retain power. Though Mojtaba does not have the Shia theological credentials needed, he is certainly a security-minded leader through whom the IRGC will try to expand its authority.

Therefore, more than ever, the military mindset — in favour of the escalation of the war with the US and Israel — is winning against the political strategy of a reduction in tensions with the West. The latter group is represented by the former Iranian president Hassan Rouhani (2013-2021), who consistently advocated for diplomacy over military conflict. It looks as if, with the intensification of bombings in Iranian cities and around the Persian-Arab Gulf area, the political line of thought is losing ground within the Iranian power structure. It is difficult to predict how and when the war will end, but it seems that neither Israel nor the US would like to deploy ground troops in this war. It looks like the greatest moments of this war for Donald Trump are the unplanned ones.

The writer is director, Mahatma Gandhi Centre for Nonviolence and Peace Studies, OP Jindal Global University



SASMIT PATRA AND ASHWIN UPRETI

AS THE proliferation of AI increasingly impacts us, one question looms large: Who gets to govern artificial intelligence? The pace and scale of AI deployment has far outstripped the ability of traditional regulatory models to ensure oversight. Historically, technology governance has been state-centric, with standards set by regulators. The emergence of artificially intelligent systems, however, disrupts this tendency.

AI-enabled systems increasingly impact labour markets, education, healthcare, finance, and even democratic processes. While technical know-how resides in private

firms, the risk and impact is borne by the public at large. This is compounded by the ability of machine-learning systems to evolve post-deployment, complicating regulation for static legal frameworks. The cumulative outcome is a fragmented ecosystem where knowledge, regulation and risk are unevenly distributed.

A participatory approach to governance offers one pathway to correct this imbalance. Such an approach would enable the diverse community of end-users, such as citizens, civil society organisations, independent researchers and academia, to detect emerging harms that domain experts or developers overlook. This is particularly helpful when bias relates to linguistic or cultural groups, regional practices or local traditions. Participatory approaches allow models to account for experiential knowledge, enabling audits

to bring contextual shortcomings to the surface. Community-led audits can further strengthen transparency and accountability by stress-testing systems under real-world conditions. However, a participatory approach to governance may only be effective when embedded in institutional design.

This requires us to reimagine governance structures. To have meaningful oversight, AI governance cannot remain in silos of state, private sector or civil society organisations. Also, intersectional coordination is contin-

If governance remains a technocratic exercise behind closed doors, AI will deepen inequalities and weaken democratic oversight

gent on infrastructure. Deliberative governance requires accessible reporting platforms and open datasets. Targeted literacy programmes are required to lower barriers to engagement and democratise knowledge.

If governance remains a technocratic exercise behind closed doors, AI will deepen inequalities and weaken democratic oversight. If India invests in qualitative institutionalised participatory mechanisms for AI audits and builds infrastructure to drive responsible innovation, AI-enabled systems can be aligned with public values rather than narrow institutional priorities. The challenge is not whether to govern AI or not, but to do so in a way that redistributes power equitably and secures public trust going forward.

Discourse around AI governance often treats opacity as a purely technical problem, locating the "black box" within proprietary

algorithms and complex model architectures. While technical opacity is real, this framing is incomplete. There is also an emerging social black box. Decisions regarding what problems are worth automating, which datasets are to be deployed for training models, whose errors are tolerable and which harms we embrace are not always made by algorithms. They are shaped by commercial value, strategic priorities and social considerations. So long as upstream choices remain opaque, even transparent AI models may produce unjust outcomes. Participatory governance mechanisms carry the prospect of piercing this veil and opening AI systems to democratic oversight.

Patra is Member of Parliament. Rajya Sabha. Upreti is assistant director at Cyril Shroff Centre for AI, Law & Regulation

Return of El Niño

This factor could cloud prospects of a bountiful southwest monsoon

DURING THE LAST five years, barring 2023, the southwest monsoon has been bountiful with normal and above normal rainfall from June to September. The big question is whether this run will be upset by the development of El Niño conditions later this year—according to the latest update from the World Meteorological Organization (WMO)—which negatively impacts the monsoon. This factor refers to the warming of sea surface waters in the central and eastern tropical Pacific Ocean, which has been associated with deficient and below normal rainfall in the country. The cooling of such waters is referred to as the La Niña factor which results in a marked increase in rainfall. Temperatures are already beginning to climb in many parts of the country, presaging much hotter summer months according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

As if all of this weren’t grounds for concern, research published in *Geophysical Research Letters* highlighted that patterns of salt distribution in the Pacific Ocean can increase the intensity of El Niño by 20% and almost double the probability of an extreme event occurring. If El Niño conditions are indeed strong, this is bad news that can result in severe drought conditions in the country. Meteorological experts, however, urge caution on drawing inferences on the El Niño factor. Madhavan Nair Rajeevan, a former secretary in the ministry of earth sciences, has reportedly stated that there was no need for panic as a better idea will emerge by June; that such conditions are expected to develop in the second half of the monsoon season and are likely to be moderate according to current predictions. Although this highly complex, dynamic system arrives with unfailing regularity, there are other factors also responsible for its behaviour—like the Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD), Eurasian snow cover, and Madden-Julian Oscillation.

While positive IOD conditions are good for rainfall, negative conditions—due to cooler sea surface temperatures in the western Indian Ocean relative to the warmer sea surface temperatures in the eastern Indian Ocean—have the effect of suppressing monsoon bursts over the Indian subcontinent. Eurasian snow cover has an inverse relationship with the monsoon. The Madden-Julian Oscillation, an equatorial travelling pattern of anomalous rainfall, also impacts the monsoon. While El Niño conditions are associated with deficient and below normal rainfall, the relationship is actually far more complex. While El Niño conditions undeniably had an impact on deficient southwest monsoon rainfall during 2014 and 2015, for instance, its impact was less clear on other episodes of below normal rainfall in the country. During 2017, warm neutral conditions prevailed during the first half of the monsoon season while cooler conditions characterised the second half, which led the IMD in its end season report to infer the absence of El Niño’s influence.

Similarly, in 2018, the IMD stated that the direct impact of the evolving El Niño on the monsoon was limited. In 2023, while El Niño conditions correlated with below normal rainfall, positive IOD conditions in the monsoon’s second half offset this deficiency. Greater clarity on the El Niño factor will of course become available when the IMD makes its first long-term forecast for the monsoon by April. But as they say, to be forewarned is to be forearmed. Contingency plans must be put in place if El Niño conditions develop this year that can affect the monsoon as indicated by agencies like the WMO.

Iran war puts India's dosa and AI dreams on ice

THE WAR IN Iran was always going to creep up on India, the world’s second-largest destination for oil exiting the Strait of Hormuz. Surprisingly, the biggest immediate impact has been on dosa and dal makhani. State-owned refiners are forced to eat their losses to keep trucks and tractors moving, but commercial kitchens are starting to crater under a severe shortage of liquefied petroleum gas, or LPG.

In the 1973 energy shock, India’s industry leaned on coal, but its homes relied on the erratic availability of liquid fuels. LPG cylinders were a rationed luxury, and all middle-class families had kerosene stoves. The situation has flipped now: buses, taxis, and kitchens have switched to some form of gas to curb pollution. But unlike oil, which can be stored in rock caverns, gas requires super-cooled tanks, or pressurised vessels. India’s storage buffer is thin, and therein lies the germ of the current crisis.

Under the Essential Commodities Act, the government has prioritised household cylinders, but commercial supplies have seized up. Restaurants are unable to serve foods requiring continuous high-energy cooking. The crisis extends beyond eateries. Huli Spirits, a jaggery rum micro-distillery in Karnataka, has decided to halt production. After paying \$9,000 a month just for a licence, a shutdown is a gut punch. Retrofitting for coal would take three months, a taller chimney, and new environmental permits—a niche startup like his can’t afford any of it, founder Aruna Urs told me.

India’s push for a more gas-based economy is centred on liquefied natural gas. Across South Asia energy firms have rolled out a \$107 billion bet on imported LNG. India is pursuing the world’s second-largest terminal capacity expansion and the third-largest gas pipeline buildout, says Global Energy Monitor. Pressing buses and autorickshaws and urban condominiums towards burning the methane contained in LNG was supposed to be a halfway house. India has been making remarkable progress in harvesting solar energy. The idea was to eventually shift demand to renewable sources, curbing emissions, and reining in a historical dependence on West Asia.

A side benefit was that it would free up local LPG output for use by the less affluent. But there was a catch. The production—basically propane and butane released during the refining of crude oil—didn’t keep pace with the new demand created by giving subsidised cylinders to 100 million new connections. That campaign is widely believed to have buttressed Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s popularity, especially in rural India, where women voters were the most exposed to toxic fumes from burning coal, wood, or cow-dung cakes.

As a result, almost 65% of India’s cooking fuel is directly imported in large vessels, and 90% of that traverses the Strait of Hormuz. The government says household supplies are stable, and it’s only misinformation that’s leading to “panic booking and hoarding”. Still, people aren’t taking chances; sales of electric cookers are soaring. Meanwhile, public facilities like 22 LPG-operated crematoriums across Pune have closed indefinitely, forcing a switch to electric in case families don’t want the traditional Hindu option of wooden pyres, which lead to felling 50–60 million trees a year nationwide. The municipal authority has said it is following the petroleum ministry’s orders to conserve gas for households.

More pain looms for the food economy. Fertiliser plants are suspending production of urea, a critical crop nutrient, as Qatari LNG supplies stall. Still, a smaller harvest is tomorrow’s problem; today’s headache is urban dislocation.

New Delhi is reportedly in talks with Tehran for safe passage of tankers, though it remains unclear if such movement is feasible from an insurance perspective. A US reprieve for India to buy Russian oil—without reprising last August’s 25% punitive tariffs—may keep traffic moving and tractors plowing. A plan to import LPG from America is also underway. While that should please President Donald Trump, the geography is punishing: A ship from Qatar reaches Gujarat in four days; a ship from the US Gulf Coast, dodging Red Sea tensions via the Cape of Good Hope, takes a month.

India’s gas transformation was supposed to help modernise the economy, at least until more environmentally ambitious plans like green hydrogen could become practical solutions. Instead, the Iran war has exposed the most-populous nation as a vulnerable commuter on the world’s energy highway. It’s keeping the home fires burning by cannibalising the very industries that provide employment to a restive youth. With the dough for the dosa getting cold in the pan, how will India ever pitch itself to AI hyperscalers as a hot destination for their next energy-hungry data centre?

● VIBE CODING

WITH THE RIGHT SCRUTINY AND SECURITY GUARDRAILS, UNDERLYING COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE AWAITS CAPTURE

Software at the speed of chat

WHAT IS VIBE coding? It’s artificial intelligence (AI) assisted programming, where those seeking to code describe their intention and creative direction in natural language, and AI tools do the rest. This includes figuring the architecture and project structure, generating code and doing the debugging, to create working software.

The term “vibe coding” was coined by AI researcher Andrej Karpathy, as AI acts as an active collaborator. Advanced versions use AI agents to collaborate more deeply—writing and running self-tests, or executing multi-file editing across the codebase, enabling rapid prototyping and quick deployment.

The popular tools for vibe coding include Cursor (for professional developers who want an integrated development environment that combines various tools into a single graphical user interface), Replit Agent for beginners, Windsurf/Cline for agentic support, Google AI Studio which leverages Gemini, and the popular Claude Code from Anthropic.

Educational and other imperatives

Considering the developments in making AI tools easier to use, one could argue that structured learning isn’t essential. What’s clearer is that mastery over all tools is a long shot, considering their abundance, and because that type of proficiency is transient. An education grounded in enduring principles is more durable. Like conceptual data flows, precision in semantics, skills to audit code, and enduring clarity of thought.

With AI handling all the grunt work, such a curriculum also signals the shift—from needing more entry level coders to more experienced orchestrators.

Investors are beginning to value product visioning, the scale and depth of the problem being solved, and market timing,

more than before.

An aside: It is advisable to be disciplined about vibe coding work hours, as developers transitioning from traditional coding to vibe coding reportedly experience a high—much like having acquired a superpower of sorts—and are inclined to work much longer hours, which could lead to burnout.

Upsides and downsides

To reiterate, entry barriers are collapsing, allowing non-technical founders to rapidly build functional software solutions at a fraction of the cost, signalling a shift away from the usual, jejune URL path. Simultaneously, as developers become orchestrators, the focus is shifting to system design and user experience. Lean tech teams at nascent startups are now building products overnight, changing the economic equation substantially.

While an AI agent creates code almost instantly, it usually lacks a global understanding of the system. Redundant libraries could be added. Over time, a vibe-coded solution could well become a black box where neither humans nor machine understand the interconnected dependencies. When AI’s context window can no longer decipher the code created, it could lead to a “vibe collapse”. Sometimes, without a complete grasp of the business context, or because of prioritising getting the

app to work, oversight pertaining to compliance or original security assumptions could also occur. Expert guidance could help preclude such hurdles.

Maintainability could be an issue too when a complex bug surfaces, owing to the cognitive ownership not residing in human minds.

Governance and cybersecurity risks

Studies reveal that AI-generated code has some inherent cyber vulnerabilities, arising from vibe coders sacrificing safe levels of threat modelling and authentication for speed. This is accentuated when the audit logic is weak, and apps deployed look perfect, but invite AI-driven exploits by hackers. Attackers are now getting smarter, concealing commands inside requests, using true or false questions to reconstruct the database structure, or making the database send information to servers they control for stealthy exfiltration of sensitive credentials.

The natural consequence of coding at the speed of chat is that human oversight becomes the bottleneck, unable to catch all security flaws or compliance drifts across vast codebases. Agentic governance could be the answer, with specialised AI supervisors playing the role of real-time gatekeepers. Vibe coding without digital guardrails is an invitation to trouble.

Scaling separates the hobbyist from production grade coding which calls for experienced, patient, nurturing hands and minds

India’s power sector has made a restructuring and called it reform. The question is not what needs to be done but who will bear the political cost of doing it

The bulb that never goes out (of the red)

ADITYA SINHA
The author writes on macroeconomic issues

IN 1879, THOMAS Edison lit a carbon filament bulb in his Menlo Park laboratory for 14.5 hours. By 1882, his Pearl Street station was supplying 85 buildings in lower Manhattan at a commercial tariff of \$0.24 per kilowatt-hour (eyewatering by any standards), yet every customer paid it, because the alternative was candles and lamp oil. There were no state distribution companies in 1882. There was also no accumulated loss of ₹7.08 lakh crore.

India’s electricity distribution sector has managed that figure (compiled by the Prayas Energy Group for the Sixteenth Finance Commission or FC) through state-owned utilities that have been bailed out in 2001, restructured in 2012, and bailed out again in 2015, emerging from each exercise approximately worse than before. The Electricity (Supply) Act of 1948, itself modelled on Britain’s Electricity (Supply) Act of 1926 and designed for an administrative structure that has since dissolved, created the vertically integrated state electricity boards that proved impossible to reform and difficult to kill. The Electricity Act of 2003 was supposed to change all this. It has now been 22 years.

Begin with the bailout record, because it is instructive. The 2001 settlement identified ₹41,473 crore of dues for restructuring; states issued tax-free bonds and signed commitments to reform. The Financial Restructuring Plan of 2012 followed, covering short-term distribution company (discom) liabilities, with participating states bound to eliminate their cost-revenue gap and enact a Model State

Electricity Distribution Responsibility Bill. The 16th FC notes, with considerable understatement, that none of the participating states met their improvement conditions, and none enacted the Model Bill. The Assurance Yojana (UDAY) arrived in 2015: ₹2.32 lakh crore in bonds, 75% of discom liabilities absorbed by state governments, another set of mandatory targets. Accumulated losses at the time of UDAY stood at ₹3.78 lakh crore. They stand today at ₹7.08 lakh crore. Three has nearly doubled.

Why does this keep recurring? Prayas offers an explanation. Between 44% and 86% of discom borrowing in eight major states goes not to capital investment but to working capital, paying generators for power already consumed, covering subsidy arrears that state governments owe but defer, and servicing old debt with new debt. Interest expenses alone account for roughly 5% of annual discom expenditure. Tamil Nadu’s discoms have accumulated ₹1.66 lakh crore in losses; in case of Rajasthan it is ₹91,565 crore; and ₹69,301 crore in Madhya Pradesh. These are not utilities in financial difficulty. They are utilities sustained by the implicit guarantee that the state government will eventually absorb whatever they cannot pay, which removes every incentive to pay.

The tariff question is where the analy-

sis turns genuinely damning. Prayas modelled what would have happened had State Electricity Regulatory Commissions simply enforced inflation-linked tariff revisions of 3.9% annually, from FY16 onwards, rather than the erratic pattern of non-revision followed by shock correction that most states prefer. The answer was ₹4.41 lakh crore in revenue gap reduction over eight years, with ₹1.6 lakh crore in interest savings. The political cost of 3.9% per year would have been a mildly unpopular annual announcement. The fiscal cost of avoiding it has been borne by every taxpayer who will eventually fund the next bailout.

What makes the Prayas report more than another diagnosis is the scale of the opportunity it documents. Battery energy storage costs have fallen from ₹11.25 lakh per megawatt per month (Kerala tender, April 2022) to ₹2.80 lakh per megawatt per month (January 2025), a 75% reduction in under three years, with no viability gap funding required in the more recent tenders. Solar combined with storage is now cost-competitive with discom industrial tariffs in 21 of 28 states. Agricultural feeder solarisation (aligning farm power supply with daylight hours, replacing subsidised grid electricity with solar) could save ₹77,558 crore annually across 12 states by FY32, with cumulative savings of ₹2.61 lakh crore between FY27 and FY32. Maha-

rashtra contracted 18.7 gigawatts of agricultural solar in roughly nine months once it decided to move.

There is a further irony. Cross-subsidies from commercial and industrial consumers, the traditional mechanism by which discoms effectively taxed industry to fund cheap power for farmers, now account for less than 10% of discom revenues, because large consumers have been moving to captive generation and open access. The argument for protecting the cross-subsidy model no longer has a model to protect. The FC recommends privatisation as the long-term answer, proposing a special purpose vehicle to warehouse accumulated working capital debt, stripped out so a private buyer might consider what remains. (In fairness, the private discoms that already exist (operating under the same tariff environment) post aggregate technical and commercial losses of 12.12% against 16.37% for state-owned ones. State-sector power projects, meanwhile, average delays of 42 months in Uttar Pradesh and 87 months in Andhra Pradesh. Private projects are commissioned on time, or close to it.

Tacitus recorded that the Romans made a desolation and called it peace. India’s power sector has made a restructuring and called it reform. The recommendations are good. They were good in 2001, in 2012, and in 2015. At some point the question is not what needs to be done but who will bear the political cost of doing it, and whether we reach the answer before the fourth bailout.

—RV Baskaran, Pune

● Write to us at feletters@expressindia.com



A thought for today

The mind is not a vessel to be filled
but a fire to be kindled

PLUTARCH

Seas On Fire

Damage of wars on oceans is everlasting, yet invisible

There are some 16 US warships – stuffed with gazillion guns, aircraft, missiles, and ammo – in Arabian and Mediterranean seas. Strait of Hormuz is aflame, as Iran deploys explosive-laden boats, targeting fuel tankers. TV news runs, in a loop, videos of jet black plumes rising up from ships ablaze – but, never, ever will there be images of the total wreckage below. News won't talk about it, either. Thing is, war kills seas, devastates marine ecosystems, destroys coastal habitats. Few people care. There're no dramatic videos. There're no smart, easy-to-grasp data points on the damage. So, yup, no one's keeping tabs on warships' debris dumped into the seas. Or on environmental cost of ships sunk. IRS Dena was torpedoed in Indian Ocean – its debris will decay, corrode, and leak – metal scrap, toxic oils, chemicals, that'll poison, and choke marine plants & animals.



Visuals of overground warfare, on land ecosystems, is horrifying enough. But, it is well-established that war's impact on seas is worse. For a simple reason. Seas are interconnected, damage is carried forward. So, when Russia battles Ukraine, on Black Sea, fallout isn't contained to warring nations' coastlines. Connected to Mediterranean Sea to its south, war's debris wrecks its way through estuaries, salt marshes, lagoons, islands, home to dolphins, whales, seabirds, uncommon species, and 2,000 plant & animal species. Chemical pollution, heat, noise, anti-sub warfare, trigger changes in animal behaviour, and species composition. They disrupt migratory patterns, throw off nesting & feeding routes. And they kill infinite numbers of creatures, great and small. Biodiversity is resilience. War kills it. Overground repercussions of land destruction, like in Gaza, or forests flattened – Ukraine rightly accused Russia of ecocide – are, however, the only talking points. Sunken ships, from two world wars, contain chemical poisons, unexploded munitions and, per IUCN, 6bn gallons of heavy fuel oil. Warming oceans have sped up their decay. So, ruinous oil spills are inevitable. Wars end, destruction undersea remains, in perpetuity. It's invisible to us. And, that ignorance is a profound tragedy.

You're Fired

Humanity's march, down to ChatGPT, is story of fire

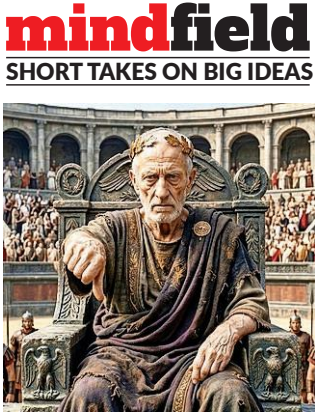
There's so much anxiety about gas out there. But it isn't about gas, really. Deep down, it's about being human. We are children of fire, and its masters, too. On current evidence, our ape-like ancestors figured out how to manage fire – mostly started by lightning – about 1.5mn years ago. Then, by a lucky accident, they started cooking, which made food not only tastier, but also more nutritious, and easier to digest. That made large digestive systems unnecessary, along with large jaws and teeth. While apes chewed their stringy, fibrous food six hours a day; for us, one hour was enough. In fact, it left us with an energy surplus, which supports brain growth. Human brains are so energy-hungry, they account for 20% of calorie burn at rest. So what? So this: without fire, there would be no Homo sapiens, and no ChatGPT. Fire also helped our brains grow, by letting us sleep long hours, without fear. A moonless night has, roughly, one-trillionth the light of a sunny day. And humans, with fewer rod cells in their eyes, are sitting ducks for leopards, and other nocturnal predators. Fire turned the scales, and not only against animals. Burning midnight oil became key to social mobility. Bricks, Roman cement, engines, cannon, Apollo missions, Tomahawk missiles, even electricity – largely – are fire's gifts. We need fire, and because gas is the only fuel most of us know how to use, we can't help being especially antsy when we can't get it.



Should Older People Be 2nd-Class Voters?

Those with their whole life ahead should have more say

Why do young people everywhere seem disenfranchised with govt? A 2021 OECD survey shows only 37% in 18-29 age group trust govt, as against 46% in 50+ cohort. In SKorea, the gap widens to 17 percentage points. In Ireland, it's 38 points. Zoom out of this rich nations' club, and a 2020 Cambridge study makes similar findings around the world. Perhaps, youth is hard to please. But if that's the case, why were 54% of 30-year-old Britons satisfied with govt in 1973? Why did satisfaction at that age increase to 57% in 1983, and 62% a decade later, before falling to 48% in 2010s? The problem is not with youth but with the way democracies are functioning, says Harvard professor Samuel Moyn, who diagnoses the problem as "gerontocracy". His book, *Gerontocracy in America: How the Old Are Hoarding Power and Wealth*, sums up the problem in its title. What's changed between, say, 1973, and now is that whole populations, not just leaders, have aged. In Britain, for example, half the population was younger than 33 then; now it's older than 40. Moyn mentions three things that make older presidents and PMs likelier now. One, old people generally vote for old people. Two, old people vote more than young people. Three: "The prevalence of aged politicians is almost certainly increasing the abstention of the young from politics and thus intensifying gerontocratic dominance..." Gerontocracy also reinforces through wealth. Older people earn more, buy or inherit the best real estate, and network at the highest levels. Even if they don't contest an election, they can pursue their agenda by propping up a young candidate. "If the voters and the wealthy are old, it may not even matter whether the politicians are young." But what is old peoples' agenda, and why is it a problem? Moyn says, "An ageing society is more set on preservation than on renovation." So, gerontocrats usher in tax cuts for the rich – themselves – rather than raising taxes to spend on schools. They place "high priority on their own needs like Medicare and social security". On the economic front, they worry about inflation, not growth. Since the elderly know they have only a few years left, their worldview tends to be short-sighted. Hence, it isn't in a society's best interest, according to Moyn. So, what can be done to prevent gerontocracy? We can't snatch wealth and property from the elderly, but Moyn suggests linking the "weight" of a vote to the age of the voter. Why? Because young people have a greater stake in every election, as they have more years to live. Since govt decisions shape the future, a 20-year-old should have a bigger say in them than someone who's 80: "Seniors are voting for potentially long-lasting outcomes they may never experience fully." Also, 18-year-old voters are the closest proxy for children who can't vote, so their votes should have more weightage, he says. Moyn suggests a couple of ways to go about this: dock 10% of a vote's weight every two years after the age of 65, or give 80-year-olds one vote, 70-year-olds two, and so on, till 20-year-olds have seven votes each. The aim is not to disenfranchise the elderly, but empower the young in proportion to their remaining lifetime.



Running scared? Nope. Playing Smart

Too many critics of GOI foreign policy are preoccupied by whether India sounds fearless. But, we are in a world of weaponised hard power. So, the priority is to, somehow, maintain operational flexibility. That's what GOI moves, on Iran war, Chinese investment, Russian oil reflect

Syed Akbaruddin



Viewing India's foreign policy debate from outside the capital has its uses. Distance makes it easier to see how starkly arguments are drawn in Delhi, and how quickly the actual constraints on Indian policy disappear from view. Today, the sharpest criticism of Indian foreign policy is that it has tilted in the wrong direction: too deferential to Washington, too comfortable in its signalling towards Israel, and too ready to adapt under American pressure, while underestimating the wider signal this sends. That criticism comes in three broad forms: dependence, asymmetry, and signalling. The dependence argument is that Delhi increasingly trims policy, to remain within an American comfort zone. The asymmetry argument is that India is more restrained in responding to American and Israeli uses of force, than to the retaliation that follows. The signalling argument is that India increasingly accepts the optics of a wider US-Israel frame. GOI's recent move on Chinese-linked investment points to something larger. India did not ease Press Note 3 because distrust of China disappeared. It adjusted because the demands of manufacturing, technology, and capital began to outweigh the signalling value of blanket rigidity. The real story is not alignment, but exposure. Indian foreign policy should now be read not through the old alignment-vs-non-alignment frame, but as an effort to manage exposure. Key exposures are energy, technology, capital, supply chains, and security. Each of these can now be weaponised by others, whether through sanctions, export controls, shipping disruption, investment restrictions, or conflict. Seen this way, some apparent inconsistencies look less like confusion, than like selective risk management. The Russia oil episode is more complicated than the above criticism suggests. India bought Russian crude at scale, because discounted oil helped contain inflation, and ease pressure on growth. When the costs of that position rose, Delhi adjusted. One reading sees capitulation. Another sees a state trying to keep

energy affordable, without inviting punitive fallout. For an import-dependent economy, it may not look elegant. It was still an effort to protect room for growth. The Iran episode sharpens the asymmetry critique, but it also reveals the order of India's concerns. India described developments in the Gulf as a matter of great anxiety, and called for dialogue, after the US-Israeli strikes on Iran triggered retaliation. Critics note the imbalance. India showed more visible urgency when Gulf stability, shipping, and energy flows were at risk, rather than when the original strikes took place. Wider international response reflected a similar pattern. On 11 March, Security Council adopted Resolution 2817, condemning Iran's retaliatory attacks on Gulf states and Jordan, but issued no comparable condemnation of the earlier strikes on Iran. That asymmetry reflects not just political preference, but India's deep exposure to the Gulf. The region bears directly on growth, inflation, remittances, energy security,



and household stability. When order in the Gulf is shaken, the effects are quickly felt across India's economy. That is where India's material dependence is greatest, and where its diplomacy is bound to be especially careful. That may not satisfy critics, but it explains more than moral outrage does. India learned this lesson long ago. In 1962, China exposed the limits of rhetoric without leverage. In 1971, facing war and external pressure, India turned to Soviet Union for strategic insurance, when doctrine alone would not do. Taken together, the lesson is the same: principles matter, but when security is at stake, states preserve themselves through leverage and partnerships, not rhetorical consistency alone. Here, the criticism is strongest, but incomplete. It is most persuasive when it warns that tactical adjustment can harden into dependence, and that signalling can slip into self-subordination. It is weakest when it assumes that autonomy is proved mainly by keeping declaratory distance from US. That is an older way of measuring freedom of action. For India today, the more serious question is whether it retains operational autonomy: enough energy flexibility, economic resilience, technological access, and strategic choice to avoid being trapped by any single pole. India was once poorer, but louder. Now it is wealthier, and more guarded. The contrast is real, but the usual conclusion is too easy. Declaratory non-alignment carried fewer costs, than today's world of weaponised interdependence. A richer India has more power, but also more exposure. The real question is not whether it sounds fearless, but whether it remains free to choose. That is why Indian foreign policy should be judged not by abstract purity, but by whether Delhi can reduce exposure without surrendering agency. In a fractured order shaped by American overreach, Chinese pressure, and weaponised economic power, that will not always look elegant. But for India, inelegance is not the worst sin. Misreading the structure of the problem, is the greater danger. The writer is a former permanent representative of India to UN

Loads Of Research Says: Don't Marry. So, Why Do We?

Economists, sociologists, psychologists...show how the wedding industrial complex takes a toll on individuality, and even on sleep. Here are 5 reasons, why marriage is bad for us, and one reason, why we won't let it go

Arash Rudra

In the short video, a couple are discussing marriage. She asks, "Babe, what is the ideal age to get married?" He gives an answer, worthy of the canned laughter that follows it: "Biologically 15 years. Legally, after 18. Culturally, 24-28 years. Economically, above 30. And logically, NEVER." Of course, internet is awash with such videos. People are forwarding it every second, confident of a chuckle at the receiving end. And, it's not just online humour. In offices up and down the world, the same kind of joke is a face-to-face staple of the watercooler conversation. Marriage is one of humanity's most durable inventions – right up there with bread, taxes, and the habit of giving advice. But all this joking about it, shows something is seriously changing. Structural quirks baked into marriage's design, are beginning to feel less cute, more unpleasant. People now pause, before signing what is, theoretically, a lifelong social contract. And many different sciences – behavioural economics, psychology, sociology – have taken a shot at explaining why marriage sucks. We list just a few insights.

Freedom tax | Chicago economists, and Nobel prizewinners, Gary Becker and Theodore Schultz, have framed marriage through household production, where time, labour, and money are jointly allocated, in a cooperative enterprise. In theory, cooperation increases efficiency. In practice, it also introduces veto power. Marriage quietly retires the luxury of unilateral decision-making. Sociologists call this "household bargaining", which sounds civilised, but often resembles a budget meeting that never quite ends. Married peeps make noticeably fewer independent lifestyle choices than their single counterparts, whether it concerns spending, or social plans, or the small matter of moving cities. "I will do this," slowly morphs into, "Should we do this?" What looks like a grammatical tweak is, in fact, a profound constitutional amendment, in the republic of personal autonomy.

Calvin & Hobbes



The Glass Ceiling Is Not Outside – It Is Within

Jaya Row

Can you imagine the world without Google? Then how can you live life without a guide? Gita gives the roadmap that takes you from mediocrity to excellence. A talented sportsperson first visualises his goal – the trophy. Then he pours his time, energy, and effort into achieving it. This means fewer hangouts with friends, staying away from his favourite food, and not lazying on a Sunday morning. Yet, it never feels like sacrifice, because the goal excites him far more than what he must give up. In the same way, begin life with a clear vision of what you want to achieve. The glass ceiling isn't outside – it is within you, in your thinking. Visualise excellence in your chosen field, in the field of your passion. Aim to be the best at it. Set smaller milestones along the way. Work dedicatedly, consistently. Love your work. Be devoted

to it. And finally, work hard. The sharper your efforts, the quicker you move forward towards your goal. You will, then, not even feel tempted to dissipate your energy in random activities. Now suppose you achieve your goal – the Olympic gold, business success, fame, and wealth. Are you fulfilled? That strange inner emptiness that drove you forward in the beginning still lingers. You begin asking, what next? Why do I still feel incomplete? Is there a way to reach lasting happiness? That's where Gita steps in. It introduces you to yourself. You are born with amazing equipment – a body, a mind, and an intellect. But were you ever given a user manual? It's like buying the most sophisticated gadget, without knowing how to use it. Sense contact gives instant happiness. The first mango of the season tastes divine.

But overindulgence dulls the joy. The more you consume mindlessly, the less you enjoy. Learn the art of discriminate contact, so the enjoyment lasts a lifetime. We seek satisfaction through action, but it often ends in pressure, comparison, and burnout. Gita introduces the concept of *yajna* – action performed in a spirit of service and sacrifice, for a higher purpose. Act with the attitude of giving, not grabbing. Modern research confirms it: givers thrive, excel, and succeed. The law is simple – give and you gain; grab and you lose. All givers are happy. And grow to their potential. Relationships begin beautifully, but expectations and demands create friction. Romance turns to resentment. The days of wine and roses, become days of wine and neuroses! Learn unconditional love. Love others irrespective of any

Sacred space



Be grateful for what you already have while you pursue your goals. If you aren't grateful for what you already have, what makes you think you would be happy with more.

Roy T Bennett



THE SPEAKING TREE



Editor's
TAKE

A World Beyond the United Nations?

The UN was founded on noble ideals for a peaceful world. Yet, in a world governed by realpolitik, the institution appears sidelined and ineffective

After the World War II ended, world leaders united to form a body that would not let the horrors of war revisit the planet. They thought of an organisation that would foster peace, encourage dialogue amongst nations, and build a mechanism to avoid conflicts and war. Fifty countries came together on 24 October 1945 to make that happen, and thus the United Nations was born – the only truly global organisation that was meant to ensure peace in the world.

Unfortunately, in more than eight decades of its existence, the UN has lost its steam and has been reduced to a world forum that can only condemn conflicts and wars. The big five – the United States, United Kingdom, France, China and Russia – the permanent members of the United Nations Security Council can easily thwart any resolution to enforce action and foster peace with their veto. The world thus does not have an effective mechanism to stop wars or a framework to prevent illegal actions by powerful nations. The war in Ukraine rages on, Israel has continued its assault on Palestine, and most recently Iran has faced the onslaught of missiles and bombers from the United States and Israel. Not only does the UN lack the teeth to punish wrongdoing, it has increasingly appeared redundant even in promoting climate consciousness, addressing crimes against humanity, fostering united action against pandemics, and tackling many other issues humanity confronts today.

The inability of the UN to prevent conflicts or enforce accountability has exposed its structural weaknesses. Does this mean that multilateral institutions are meaningless? Certainly not. On the contrary, they remain our only hope. Our approach should be to recalibrate them for a changing world order.

In recent years, several smaller groupings have emerged, such as Conference of the Parties (COP) and the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (QUAD). The approach should be to integrate such platforms within the broader UN system so that it can effectively coordinate critical humanitarian operations, peacekeeping missions, and development initiatives that smaller or regional alliances cannot easily replicate. What is required, therefore, is not the dismantling the UN but reforming it to make it more representative, aligning with the present situation. Today's world is very different from what it looked like after World War II in 1945. Emerging powers, developing economies, and regions such as Africa and South Asia must receive greater representation in global decision-making structures. For India, this evolving landscape presents both an opportunity and a responsibility. As a rising global power with longstanding commitments to multilateralism, India is uniquely positioned to bridge the gap between global institutions and regional partnerships. In this transitional world order, India has the potential to act both as a reformer of global institutions and as a constructive participant in emerging strategic partnerships. The time has come to build an effective multilateral organisation – whether under the name of the UN or otherwise – capable of managing the crucial affairs of the planet. After all, it is the only place we have to live.

When politics had moral role models

At a moment when the world appears increasingly unstable-conflicts escalating in regions such as the Middle East, threats of military retaliation, and the looming possibility of wider war-the need for moral leadership feels more urgent than ever



RACHITA
RAMYA

There are many quotes attributed to Mahatma Gandhi that often require verification-whether it is “An eye for an eye makes the whole world blind,” or the idea that when someone slaps you on the right cheek, you offer the left. Yet perhaps one of the most relevant principles associated with Gandhi today is simpler and more direct: The best politics is right action.

At a moment when the world appears increasingly unstable-conflicts escalating in regions such as the Middle East, threats of military retaliation, and the looming possibility of wider war-the need for moral leadership feels more urgent than ever. When global politics seems driven by power, retaliation, and strategic interests rather than human consequences, the world longs for leaders who remind us that peace is essential for survival and flourishing.

There was a time when figures like Mahatma Gandhi and Martin Luther King Jr. served as moral role models for political leaders. Their ideas shaped a generation that believed politics could be guided by ethics as much as by ambition. Leaders looked to such figures not for perfection but for principles-lessons about courage, restraint, and justice.

Today, however, we live in an age of relentless scrutiny and “cancel culture”, where historical figures are often judged solely by their flaws. Certainly, no individual is beyond criticism, and honest historical reflection is necessary. Yet in our eagerness to expose mistakes, we sometimes forget the moral frameworks these leaders provided. Their influence once encouraged politicians to measure themselves against ethical standards that seem increasingly absent in contemporary politics.

One Indian politician who embodied many of Gandhi's ideals was Shankar Dayal Singh, who, as a young man, had the rare opportunity to meet Gandhi in 1947, leaving a lasting impression. Though Gandhi would be assassinated within a year, the values he represented-simplicity, moral courage, and service-remained deeply etched in Singh's outlook. In 1971, Singh joined the Congress and was among the youngest members to serve in the Fifth Lok Sabha. He conducted himself with dignity and integrity, as a dynamic yet idealistic politician untouched by moral and financial corruption, mirroring Gandhi's teachings.

Much like Gandhi, Singh demonstrated defiance towards those in power. However, in Singh's case, it was the Congress leadership



AS GANDHI
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CITIZENS

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 The Pioneer

under scrutiny. During the Emergency, Singh quietly helped in sheltering political figures such as Krishan Kant despite his own proximity to the leadership, which reflected a moral courage rarely seen in political circles and reaffirmed Gandhi's philosophy: The best politics is right action. With Gandhi acting as his moral compass, Singh gave weight not to ambition and power, but to idealism and the dignity of doing what is right for the general public.

In one of his notable works, Emergency: Fact and Fiction, Singh drew a striking contrast between Indira Gandhi and Mahatma Gandhi, arguing that the two figures represented opposing moral visions of India. He wrote that while Mahatma Gandhi sought to uplift and live among the poor, Indira Gandhi's politics increasingly distanced itself from those ideals. He argued that Mahatma Gandhi wore hand-spun khadi and attempted to dissolve divisions of caste and religion, while Indira Gandhi's politics deepened social and political lines.

The contrast extended symbolically to lifestyle and philosophy: Singh advocated throughout his life for khadi, swadeshi goods, and the promotion of Hindi as a unifying cultural language. Yet his advocacy was rooted not in exclusion but in a broader respect for India's religious and cultural diversity. Despite his contributions as a parliamentarian, writer, and advocate of

Gandhian ethics, figures like Shankar Dayal Singh have gradually faded from public memory. Our age tends to remember scandals and controversies more readily than integrity and service. In an era of social media, where public service is curated and admiration is carefully manufactured, this was an organic affection-free of transaction or calculation, born simply from Singh's lifelong commitment to moral integrity and virtue of character.

Gandhi himself has been the subject of intense criticism in recent years. Yet acknowledging his flaws does not erase the transformative power of his ideas. His philosophy of non-violence and civil resistance shifted the balance of power away from weapons and towards the collective strength of ordinary people.

Perhaps the deeper question we must ask ourselves today is this: too often, we vote based on narrow calculations, choosing what seems like the “lesser evil” rather than asking larger moral questions. We may ask whether a politician will benefit us personally, but rarely do we ask whether their actions will be just for others, for the environment, or for future generations.

The world today could benefit from a return to such idealism.

As Gandhi reminded us, The best politics is right action. And right action begins with the choices we make as citizens.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

After all, what are wars all about?

explained as pre-emptive action taken to install peace. It's all for the sake of eventual amity, the warmongers disguised as peacekeepers say, making a case for the terror they unleash. This language of peace that sounds controlled, defensive, or morally justified is wickedly flawed and makes blood-letting look like a worthy cause to pursue in the long run. If war must be justified as the protection of righteousness, like it was done in the Mahabharata, there should be a clear-cut classification of who is righteous and who is not. Apparently, the one who made the opening gambit in the present crisis cannot make any claim to such virtues. If a trigger-happy, megalomaniac politician sells war to the world in the name of peace, no one is going to buy it.

Sadly, most armed conflicts of this nature are fallout of decades of hostility, betrayal and mutual suspicion that have piled up over time. As years pass, the historical background gets overshadowed by power equations, and if there is one thing that violence cannot achieve, it is peace.

So then, are these wars merely projections of force and domination? Are they statements about who the masters are and who the minions are? Such questions invite us to look deeper into the psychology of human beings and the thought patterns that drive our actions. The craving to win keeps most of us running, jostling, scrambling and elbowing one another in the race - striving to outdo everyone else and reach the top so that we become the undisputed master of all we survey. Yet this is not the whole truth.

The hunger for supremacy is rooted in the ego - a sense of self built around our achievements, beliefs and place in the world. It seeks constant validation and keeps repeating that “I matter” in the larger scheme of the universe. The ego cannot bear to be ignored or sidelined. It feeds on authority, regardless of the method used to obtain it. The primacy it demands is insatiable. At the slightest threat to its dominance or survival, it strikes. The instinct to survive overwhelms every other emotion. The fear of losing our identity and everything we hold dear becomes our greatest weakness. Fear is humanity's ultimate adversary — the fear of loss, dispossession, insignificance and death. These fears accumulate and often translate into oppression, aggression and the primal urge to eliminate threats, both real and imagined. Those who

occupy the highest positions of power and privilege often suffer from these impulses more intensely than those who have little to lose. What we are witnessing across the world today is an illustration of how the insecurities of powerful individuals can result in the death and destruction of countless innocent lives. No war, however cleverly justified, can restore lasting order or stability. The victory of one side — always temporary — only deepens resentment and grief among the defeated. True peace cannot emerge while self-importance and hubris guide human intentions.

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Questioning the roots of war

The attacks on Iran by the United States and Israel must stop immediately. Ordinary people across the world are already suffering from the economic consequences of war. In our town, we once gathered at tea shops to drink tea and discuss the news. Today, many of those tea shops cannot even serve tea or snacks because of the shortage of LPG gas. The families that depend on these shops for their livelihood are struggling to survive. The reach of American imperialism now extends even to our food bowls. If this situation continues, its effects may soon reach our homes. Few realise that American imperialism controls nearly 50 per cent of the world's arms supply. The arms trade grew by about four per cent in 2024, generating profits of roughly 338 billion dollars. Such profits come at the cost of human suffering.

Like the British once ruled by dividing people along religious and caste lines, today powerful nations expand their influence through conflict and division.

India has before it the paths shown by Mahatma Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru — the path of peace, scientific progress and national development. We must follow those ideals rather than allow our society to be dragged into conflict and division.

UNNIKRISHNAN MANGALASSERI | KERALA

Clean rivers are national assets

Rivers are national assets, yet awareness about protecting their purity and usefulness remains inadequate. Rivers are indispensable for everyday needs, agriculture and drinking water. They also serve as important inland transport routes that can strengthen trade and commerce. River systems represent some of the most biologically diverse ecosystems on Earth. However, only about ten per cent of the world's river basins are protected. Human activities such as dam construction, encroachment, deforestation and pollution have severely threatened their existence.

Saving and celebrating rivers must therefore become a priority for governments, communities and individuals. People must ensure that rivers remain free from garbage, sewage and industrial waste. No nation can allow its rivers to become dumping grounds for pollution. River management, pollution control and conservation must be treated as critical priorities. Every year on March 14, more than thirty countries observe the International Day of Action for Rivers, reflecting on ways to protect rivers and uphold the principle: “Protect Rivers, Protect People.” Only through collective responsibility can we safeguard rivers for future generations.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Rahul corners government on oil policy

This refers to the report, “Government bartered India's oil rights to US: Rahul Gandhi” (March 13). Rahul Gandhi has repeatedly accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi of surrendering to the United States and undermining India's sovereignty. According to him, the government compromised the country's energy security and allowed foreign influence to shape India's decisions. He claims that oil purchases were directed by US President Donald Trump, thereby weakening India's autonomy in critical energy matters. Rahul Gandhi has also argued that government policies have triggered an energy crisis leading to shortages and instability.

Such serious allegations require a clear response from the Prime Minister, as silence may be misread as acceptance.

The government should clarify that India's energy decisions are sovereign and guided by national interest. India has diversified oil imports, expanded renewable energy and built strategic reserves, sourcing oil from multiple regions despite external pressure. The global energy crisis stems largely from geopolitical conflicts and market volatility, not domestic mismanagement. The Prime Minister should reaffirm India's independent energy policy.

O PRASADA RAO | HYDERABAD

PIC TALK



A man participates in an event to make 1.25 crore clay Shivlings during a Srimad Bhagwat Katha in Bhopal.

PHOTO: PTI

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WEST ASIA WAR THREATENS STABILITY AND INDIA'S ENERGY SECURITY

Washington appeared to aim for a swift regime change in Tehran by launching a sudden, massive attack on Iran and targeting its supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. The objective seemed to be gaining greater control over the region and its oil reserves. However, the ongoing military campaign, reportedly called Operation Epic Fury, shows no visible signs of ending.

The bombings have caused severe destruction in Tehran, while Iran's retaliatory missile strikes have inflicted damage in Israel. Gulf nations are increasingly uneasy about the Iranian attacks, which have shaken their confidence in U.S. military protection. At the same time, European countries in the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation have begun serious discussions on achieving greater

defence self-reliance. The possibility of closer strategic alignment between China, Russia, North Korea and Iran is also being widely discussed. In this evolving geopolitical landscape, India is often perceived as being aligned with the United States and Israel.

The cost of imported crude oil and LPG has surged sharply, while tensions around the Strait of Hormuz have disrupted supply routes. India's dependence on crude oil imports has steadily increased, reaching nearly 89 per cent by early 2026. Imports account for around 60 per cent of the country's LPG consumption, with most shipments passing through the Strait. Any disruption has immediate consequences for industries and households alike.

HARIDASAN RAJAN | KERALA

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com.
In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.